A dissertation in film theory, comparative mythology, and Black critical thought

Shipwreck Without Shore

Vicarity, Fatal Sight, and the Three Wishes of the Monkeypaw in the Cinema of Jordan Peele

October 2026

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Abstract

This dissertation argues that the cinema of Jordan Peele constitutes a single, sustained philosophical inquiry into a structure of American modernity that I designate *vicarity*: the organized arrangement whereby certain bodies are made to bear, in the place of others, the labor, sensation, risk, visibility, and death that those others wish to experience only at a safe remove. Vicarity is at once an economic order (fungibility, substitution, extraction), an ontological order (the allocation of personhood and of its negation), and a spectatorial order, whose classical emblem is the Lucretian spectator who finds it sweet to watch, from land, another's ordeal upon a storm-churned sea. I contend that this spectatorial order forms an unwritten clause, the *vicarious contract*, of what Charles W. Mills theorized as the Racial Contract, and that the horror film is its secular sacrament: the institution in which the safe remove is nightly rehearsed, purchased, and ratified.

Peele's directorial triptych, *Get Out* (2017), *Us* (2019), and *Nope* (2022), stages the progressive breach of that contract, and the dissertation reads the three films as one composition organized along four concurrent axes. First, they enact in sequence the three wishes of W. W. Jacobs's "The Monkey's Paw" (1902), the tale from which Peele's production company takes its name: the wish for compensation (a body converted into value), the wish for return (the buried double knocking at the door), and the wish for expulsion (the thing sent back whence it came), each granted with literalist malice and each paid for by a substitute. Second, they traverse a vertical cosmology of capture, from the endopsychic hold of the Sunken Place through the chthonic hold of the Tethered's tunnels to the ouranic hold of a predator concealed in a cloud, which answers to Christina Sharpe's figures of the hold, the ship, and the weather. Third, they rehearse in American idiom the doctrine of fatal sight that Ovid compiled in the Theban third book of the *Metamorphoses*: Actaeon's unspeakable *ego sum*, Narcissus's specular *iste ego sum*, and Semele's incineration before an epiphany no mortal body can bear. Fourth, their titles compose a grammar of spectatorial address

(imperative, deictic, negative) that inscribes the Black audience's practice of talking back to the screen into the films' very names.

The formal engine common to these axes I term *Monkeypaw poetics*: the conjunction of Jacobs's literalized wish with the double-voiced Signifyin(g) that Henry Louis Gates Jr. theorized through the African diasporic trickster, whereby the dominant order's metaphors, euphemisms, and wishes are taken at their word and returned as curses. Situating Peele within genealogies that run from Charles W. Chesnutt's conjure tales, the Haitian *zonbi*, and the comic tradition of Richard Pryor, Eddie Murphy, and Dave Chappelle, through Ira Levin, George A. Romero, Wes Craven, and Rod Serling, and across mythological fiction from Hans Christian Andersen and Franz Kafka to Octavia E. Butler, Neil Gaiman, and Guillermo del Toro, the study concludes that Peele's cinema proposes a post-vicarious ethics of spectatorship that I call *mediated opacity*: a synthesis of the Orphic prohibition and the Persean mirror, in which the subject refuses to meet the devouring gaze face to face while seizing, from below, the apparatus that would capture it. Peele's horror, the dissertation finally argues, abolishes the shore. It discloses that the spectator who presumed to watch the wreck from land had been standing all along on the deck of the ship.

Prefatory Note on Corpus, Method, and Nomenclature

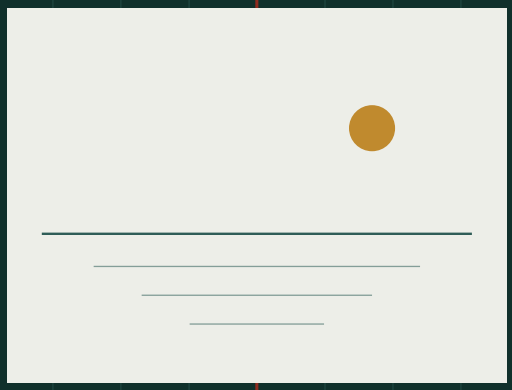
Corpus. The primary corpus comprises the three features Peele has written and directed: *Get Out* (2017), *Us* (2019), and *Nope* (2022). The secondary corpus comprises work in which his authorship is shared, curatorial, or performative: the sketch series *Key & Peele* (2012–2015), co-created and performed with Keegan-Michael Key, together with his earlier tenure on *MADtv* (2003–2008); *Keanu* (2016), co-written with Alex Rubens; *The Twilight Zone* (2019–2020), which he executive produced and hosted in Rod Serling's former chair; *Candyman* (2021), co-written with Win Rosenfeld and the film's director, Nia DaCosta; the stop-motion *Wendell & Wild* (2022), co-written with Henry Selick; and productions mounted under the Monkeypaw banner, among them *BlacKkKlansman* (2018), *Hunters* (2020–2023), *Lovecraft Country* (2020), *Monkey Man* (2024), and *Him* (2025). Peele's fourth directorial feature lies outside the corpus by necessity. Once dated for 2024 and since withdrawn from Universal's calendar, it remained unscheduled in June 2026, when trade reporting indicated only that a script had at last been settled; the same report noted that *Him*'s commercial failure had left Monkeypaw without another greenlit feature (World of Reel, relaying *Puck*, 19 June 2026). The corpus is therefore closed as of October 2026, and the dissertation treats it as a completed phase.

Method. The study proceeds constellationally, in Walter Benjamin's sense: it assembles heterogeneous materials (films, sketches, myths, scriptures, philosophical treatises, historical episodes) not as links in a chain of influence but as points whose configuration discloses a figure visible in none of them alone. Three procedures are braided. The first is formal analysis of mise-en-scène, sound, montage, and performance, attentive to the ways in which Peele's images think. The second is a critical apparatus drawn from Black studies (Du Bois, Fanon, Spillers, Hartman, Wilderson, Sharpe, Moten), psychoanalysis (Freud, Rank, Lacan, Kristeva), apparatus and spectatorship theory (Baudry, Metz, Mulvey, Diawara, hooks), and the critique of political economy (Marx, Du Bois, Robinson, Gilmore). The third is a comparative mythography I call *conjunctural*: it treats myth neither as a repository of Jungian archetypes nor as a store of decorative allusion but, following Claude Lévi-Strauss, as a logical instrument for working through contradictions a culture cannot resolve and, following Hans Blumenberg, as the labor by which a culture interposes distance between itself and the "absolutism of reality." Where the archive is silent, above all on the lives of those whose im-

ages and labor underwrote the culture of spectacle, the study adopts Saidiya Hartman's discipline of critical fabulation: speculation constrained by the archive's own fractures, offered as hypothesis rather than recovered fact. Claims about authorial intention are minimized and flagged; claims about what the films do are made without apology. Parenthetical dates refer to first publication or release. Translations from Greek, Latin, German, and French are my own unless otherwise indicated; scriptural citations follow the King James Version.

Nomenclature. The argument requires a small lexicon of coinages, defined here and developed in the chapters that follow.

Term	Definition
Vicarity	The organized arrangement whereby certain bodies bear, in the place of others, the labor, sensation, risk, visibility, and death that those others wish to experience only at a safe remove; from Latin *vicarius*, "substitute, deputy."
The vicarious contract	The unwritten spectatorial clause of the Racial Contract: the signatories' presumed right to experience through non-signatories the perils from which they themselves are exempt.
The Lucretian clause	The contract's aesthetic provision, named for *De rerum natura* II.1–4: the sweetness of watching, from land, another's ordeal at sea.
Monkeypaw poetics	Peele's formal engine: the literalization of the dominant order's wishes and metaphors (after W. W. Jacobs) executed through the trickster's double-voiced Signifyin(g) (after Henry Louis Gates Jr.).
The Jacobsian triad	The three wishes of "The Monkey's Paw" as the structural sequence of the trilogy: compensation (*Get Out*), return (*Us*), expulsion (*Nope*).
The three holds	The trilogy's vertical cosmology of capture: endopsychic (the Sunken Place), chthonic (the Tethered's tunnels), ouranic (the predator in the cloud).
The Ovidian triad	Three formulas of selfhood under the regime of fatal sight drawn from *Metamorphoses* III: the unspeakable I (Actaeon), the specular I (Narcissus), the incinerated I (Semele).
Metaphysical arithmetic	The ratio of minds to bodies in each film: two minds in one body (possession); one soul in two bodies (duplication); one eye and no interior, swallowing a multitude (consumption).
Grammar of address	The progression of the titles through three speech acts: imperative (*Get Out*), deictic (*Us*), negative (*Nope*).
Bifocal address	The construction of images that produce divergent, simultaneous spectatorships across the color line.
Mediated opacity	The post-vicarious ethic the trilogy proposes: refusal of the face-to-face with the devouring gaze, joined to the seizure of the apparatus from below.



Introduction

The Spectator on the Shore

O, I have suffered / With those that I saw suffer

William Shakespeare, *The Tempest* (1611), I.ii

I. *Suave, mari magno*

The second book of Lucretius's *De rerum natura* opens with an image that has served Western thought for two millennia as the emblem of a certain pleasure:

> *Suave, mari magno turbantibus aequora ventis, / e terra magnum alterius spectare laborem; / non quia vexari quemquamst iucunda voluptas, / sed quibus ipse malis careas quia cernere suave est.*
>
> Sweet it is, when winds are churning the waters of the great sea, to watch from land another's great ordeal; not because anyone's torment is a joyful delight, but because it is sweet to discern the evils from which you yourself are free. (II.1–4)

Lucretius's disclaimer is precise and therefore damning. The pleasure he describes is not sadism; it requires no enjoyment of the other's suffering as such. It is the pleasure of exemption, and exemption is relational: it requires that the ordeal be real, that it be another's, and that a line, the shoreline, separate the two. The Epicurean ideal of *ataraxia* is figured here as a structural position that exists only by contrast with a troubled soul glimpsed at a distance. Remove the foundering sailor and the sweetness evaporates. The spectator's tranquillity is, in the strict sense, parasitic.

Modern aesthetics secularized this structure without dismantling it. Edmund Burke's *Enquiry* (1757) opens its discussion of sympathy with a confession: "I am convinced we have a degree of delight, and that no small one, in the real misfortunes and pains of others" (Part I, §XIV). The delight is conditional upon distance; danger and pain, when they press too nearly, are simply terrible, "but at certain distances, and with certain modifications, they may be, and they are delightful" (Part I, §VII). Kant's dynamical sublime (1790, §28) installs the same proviso at the center of the critical system: thunderclouds, volcanoes, hurricanes, and the boundless ocean in tumult grow more attractive the more fearsome they are, provided only that we find ourselves in safety. In Hans Blumenberg's genealogy *Shipwreck with Spectator* (1979), the Lucretian figure becomes the paradigm of a whole metaphorics of existence, whose decisive modern torsion arrives with Pascal's reply to the libertine who would decline the wager: *vous êtes embarqué*, you are embarked. The modern subject has lost the shore; no standpoint remains outside the sea from which the wreck might be enjoyed.

This dissertation argues that the cinema of Jordan Peele stages Pascal's correction of Lucretius with a historical specificity that neither Pascal nor Blumenberg supplied. Peele's films demonstrate that in the Atlantic world the shore was never a natural vantage but a manufactured one, built and maintained by a juridical, economic, and aesthetic order that assigned some bodies

to the sea so that others might stand on land. They demonstrate, further, that the institution charged with keeping that vantage pleasurable, the horror film, was itself a clause in the arrangement. And they demonstrate, finally, that the arrangement can be breached.

II. The Ship beneath the Metaphor

The Lucretian sea acquired, in the eighteenth and nineteenth centuries, a historical body. In 1781 the crew of the slave ship *Zong*, off course and short of water, threw more than 130 captive Africans into the sea; the owners subsequently claimed the insured value of the drowned as jettisoned cargo, and the ensuing litigation, *Gregson v. Gilbert* (1783), adjudicated the massacre as a question of maritime insurance. In 1840 J. M. W. Turner exhibited *Slavers Throwing Overboard the Dead and Dying—Typhoon Coming On*, whose foreground sea teems with shackled limbs and devouring fish. John Ruskin, who came to own the canvas, lavished upon it some of the most celebrated prose in English criticism, dwelling on the incarnadine sea, the "guilty ship," and masts written upon the sky in blood, while consigning the drowning captives, the painting's ostensible subject, to a footnote. Paul Gilroy (1993) made that footnote emblematic of a culture able to aestheticize the Middle Passage only by subordinating its human content to the sublime.

The *Zong* and the Ruskinian footnote are the two faces of a single regime. In the first, the drowned are converted into compensable value: their deaths are priced, insured, and litigated, and the price substitutes for the persons. In the second, the drowned are converted into spectacle: their deaths occasion an aesthetic experience enjoyed at a remove, and the experience substitutes for the persons. Ian Baucom (2005) reads the *Zong* as a primal scene of speculative finance; M. NourbeSe Philip's *Zong!* (2008) dismembers the court record until it testifies against itself; Christina Sharpe's *In the Wake* (2016) recasts the coordinates of Black being in what Saidiya Hartman named the afterlife of slavery as the wake, the ship, the hold, and the weather. In each case the ship is the figure the Lucretian shore requires and conceals. The spectator stands on land because someone else is in the hold.

III. From the Racial Contract to the Vicarious Contract

Charles W. Mills argued in *The Racial Contract* (1997) that the social contract of modern political philosophy conceals a prior and more fundamental agreement among those designated white to categorize the remainder of humanity as subpersons, an agreement at once political, moral, and epistemological. Its epistemological dimension Mills called an "epistemology of ignorance": an inverted cognition by which the contract's beneficiaries are structurally

unable to understand the world they have made. Carole Pateman's *The Sexual Contract* (1988) had performed the analogous operation upon patriarchal right. I propose that the Racial Contract contains a further clause that neither Mills nor his interlocutors isolated, a *vicarious contract*, under which the signatories reserve the right to have others labor, suffer, risk, feel, be seen, and die in their stead, and to experience those others' perils, when they so desire, from a safe remove.

Vicarity, as I use the term, names a single structure operating in three registers. In the economic register it is fungibility: the convertibility of the captive body into whatever value its holder requires, which Hartman (1997) identified as the condition rendering the enslaved an empty vessel for the projected feelings and desires of others, and which Hortense Spillers (1987) located in the reduction of body to flesh, the zero degree of social conception. Marx had already supplied the structure's Gothic idiom in 1867: "Capital is dead labour, that, vampire-like, only lives by sucking living labour." In the ontological register vicarity is what Orlando Patterson (1982) called social death and what Frank B. Wilderson III (2010; 2020) theorizes as the structural position of the Black as the being against whom the Human is defined, upon whom gratuitous violence is performed so that others may be secured in their humanity. In the spectatorial register vicarity is the Lucretian clause itself, and here Hartman's analysis is decisive. Reading the abolitionist John Rankin's *Letters on American Slavery* (1833), in which the author, to make his slaveholding brother feel slavery's horror, imagines his own wife and children in the place of the enslaved, Hartman shows that sympathetic identification operates by substitution: the captive's suffering becomes legible only when transposed onto a white body, and the captive is effaced in the very act of being pitied. Empathy, on this analysis, is not the antidote to vicarity but one of its instruments.

The word carries a theological charge that the argument will exploit. Latin *vicarius* names a deputy, and Christian soteriology elaborated, from Isaiah's Suffering Servant to Anselm's *Cur Deus Homo* (c. 1098), a doctrine of substitutionary atonement: "he was wounded for our transgressions, he was bruised for our iniquities: the chastisement of our peace was upon him; and with his stripes we are healed" (Isaiah 53:5). In an American context the stripes cannot be read innocently. James H. Cone's *The Cross and the Lynching Tree* (2011) traced the identity of the crucified and the lynched, and Delores S. Williams's *Sisters in the Wilderness* (1993) argued, in a foundational work of womanist theology, that Black women's historical experience of coerced surrogacy, as mammies, as forced breeders, as substitutes for white women in labor and in sexual service, renders suspect at its root any theology that sanctifies surrogacy as redemptive. Vicarity is therefore not only a political economy and a spectatorial habit. It is a liturgy, and it has its sacraments.

IV. Horror as Sacrament

The horror film is one of them. The genre's theoretical literature has long circled the paradox Noël Carroll (1990) formulated: why should audiences seek out representations of what they would flee in life? Aristotle had answered for tragedy that it accomplishes, through pity and fear, the catharsis of such emotions. Carroll answers through curiosity, the fascination of an impossible being whose disclosure the narrative withholds. Robin Wood (1979) answers through the return of the repressed: the monster is what normality must disavow in order to remain normal, and the genre stages its return in order to contain it. Carol Clover (1992) answers through identification: the spectator, against the grain of the sadistic gaze Laura Mulvey (1975) theorized, suffers alongside the Final Girl. Isabel Pinedo (1997) answers through bounded experience, horror as "recreational terror," fear made safe by its frame. Linda Williams (1991) answers through the body: horror is a body genre in which the spectator's flesh involuntarily imitates the flesh onscreen.

Each answer presupposes the Lucretian clause. Catharsis, curiosity, the containment of the repressed, masochistic identification, recreational fear, and bodily mimicry all require that the terror be undergone by another, upon a screen, at a distance underwritten by the theater's darkness and the ticket's price. The horror film is the sacrament of vicarity in the precise theological sense: a visible sign of an invisible arrangement. Someone dies in the spectator's place, and the spectator walks out into the night bearing the sweetness of exemption.

The genre's racial history makes the sacramental structure unmistakable. Robin R. Means Coleman's *Horror Noire* (2011) documents a century in which Black characters served as comic relief, sacrificial guides, or first casualties. Duane Jones's Ben in George A. Romero's *Night of the Living Dead* (1968) survives the night only to be shot by a posse that takes him for a ghoul. Dick Hallorann in Stanley Kubrick's *The Shining* (1980), a film Peele's work repeatedly cites, crosses the continent to rescue a white family and is killed on arrival by a single stroke of an axe. John Coffey in *The Green Mile* (1999), whose initials announce his typology, literally draws sickness out of white bodies into his own before he is executed; he is the purest figure the genre has produced of the substitute whose stripes heal. These are not lapses of representation. They are the liturgy performed correctly.

V. Thesis

Against this background the central claim of the dissertation can be stated. Jordan Peele's three features constitute a single composition whose subject is vicarity and whose action is the breach of the vicarious contract. They are

organized along four concurrent axes, each developed in the chapters that follow and synthesized in the sixth.

The first axis is structural. Peele's production company takes its name from W. W. Jacobs's tale of 1902, in which a talisman brought home from colonial service grants three wishes to a family named, with a bluntness the twenty-first century cannot overlook, White. The first wish, for two hundred pounds, is granted as compensation paid by the firm whose machinery has mangled the family's son. The second, for the son's return, is granted as a knocking at the door in the night. The third, uttered as the door is about to open, sends the thing back into the dark. *Get Out*, *Us*, and *Nope* enact these wishes in order: compensation (a body converted into value), return (the buried double at the door), expulsion (the devouring thing returned to the sky).

The second axis is cosmological. The films descend and ascend through three holds: the endopsychic hold of the Sunken Place beneath the self, the chthonic hold of the Tethered's tunnels beneath the nation, and the ouranic hold of a predator concealed in a cloud above the land. These answer to Sharpe's hold, ship, and weather.

The third axis is mythological. The trilogy rehearses, in American idiom, the doctrine of fatal sight that Ovid compiled in the third book of the *Metamorphoses*, the Theban book of Cadmus, Actaeon, Semele, Tiresias, Narcissus, and Pentheus. Its governing formulas are Actaeon's unspeakable *ego sum*, Narcissus's specular *iste ego sum*, and the incineration of Semele before the unbearable epiphany of Jupiter.

The fourth axis is rhetorical. The titles constitute a grammar of spectatorial address: an imperative shouted at the protagonist (*Get Out*), a pronoun that enrolls the audience in the national subject (*Us*), a vernacular negation that refuses the spectacle (*Nope*). Each title is the audience's line, and together they move from warning another, through recognizing oneself, to refusal.

The method binding these axes is Monkeypaw poetics, and the ethic toward which they tend is mediated opacity. Peele's cinema does not merely represent vicarity. It implicates its spectators in vicarity and then revokes their exemption.

VI. State of the Field and Claims to Originality

Scholarship on Peele has developed with unusual speed and along recognizable lines. Historical surveys of Black horror, preeminently Coleman's, supply the genealogy into which *Get Out* is typically inserted as culmination and rupture. Tananarive Due's teaching and criticism, together with her role in the 2019 documentary adaptation of *Horror Noire*, have articulated a Black horror aesthetic grounded in survival. Kinitra D. Brooks's *Searching for Sycorax* (2017) has reoriented the field toward Black women's hauntings and away

from a male-centered canon. Dawn Keetley's edited volume *Jordan Peele's Get Out: Political Horror* (2020) consolidated the reading of the first film as political allegory. Peele's own designation "social thriller," and the contested trade category "elevated horror," have framed much journalistic reception.

Three tendencies characterize this literature. It reads the films singly, as allegories of discrete problems: liberal appropriation, class stratification, the attention economy. It elevates race, class, or spectacle to master term, generating a recurrent debate, sharpest around *Us*, over whether Peele abandoned the first for the second. And it treats mythological reference, where it registers it at all, as allusion rather than as structure. To the best of my knowledge the following claims are new: that the trilogy constitutes a single composition organized by the Jacobsian triad; that vicarity integrates the economic, ontological, and spectatorial registers that existing readings hold apart, and thereby dissolves the race-versus-class impasse; that the films rehearse Ovid's Theban doctrine of fatal sight in a determinate sequence; that their titles form a grammar of address; and that the trilogy proposes, in mediated opacity, a coherent post-vicarious ethics of spectatorship.

VII. Architecture

Chapter One reconstructs the genealogy of Monkeypaw poetics in Peele's comedy and in the African American and Gothic traditions he inherits, from Chesnutt's conjure tales and the Haitian *zonbi* to Gates's Signifying Monkey and Jacobs's paw. Chapters Two, Three, and Four read *Get Out*, *Us*, and *Nope* as studies in possessive, reciprocal, and spectacular vicarity respectively. Chapter Five extends the analysis to the wider Monkeypaw corpus and places Peele within a comparative constellation of horror and mythological fiction. Chapter Six states the general theory, tabulates its axes, and confronts the strongest objections to it. The Conclusion assesses the theory's yield for horror studies, Black studies, film theory, and mythography.

1

Chapter One

Change the Joke and Slip the Yoke

Genealogies of Monkeypaw Poetics

Slaves sing most when they are most unhappy.

Frederick Douglass, *Narrative of the Life of Frederick Douglass* (1845)

Peele's horror is the continuation of his comedy by other means. Both are assembled from a single formal unit, the literalization of a social metaphor, and both descend from African American traditions of the trickster tale and the conjure narrative, which had long wielded the gap between literal and figurative meaning as a weapon against those who could read only one way. This chapter reconstructs that genealogy and defines the method it produced.

1.1 The Mechanical Encrusted upon the Living

Henri Bergson's *Le Rire* (1900) located the source of laughter in *du mécanique plaqué sur du vivant*, something mechanical encrusted upon the living: the person who behaves like a thing, the gesture that repeats with the rigidity of a mechanism, the body that persists in a routine after circumstance has changed. Freud's "The Uncanny" (1919), following Ernst Jentsch, located a principal source of dread in precisely the same zone: the uncertainty whether an apparently animate being is alive, or whether a lifeless object might be animate, epitomized by the automaton Olimpia in E. T. A. Hoffmann's "Der Sandmann" (1816), a tale whose other obsession is the theft of eyes. The comic and the uncanny are thus produced by one device under different conditions of stake. When the mechanized human is harmless, we laugh; when its mechanization signifies that someone has been emptied out and something else installed, we scream. Noël Carroll's argument (1999) that horror and humor share a structure of incongruity, diverging only in whether the incongruity threatens, gives the observation its philosophical form.

Peele's oeuvre is the most sustained demonstration of this kinship in American popular culture. The groundskeeper Walter's nocturnal sprint toward the camera, the housekeeper Georgina's fixed smile beneath a running tear, the Tethered's jerky, belated mimicry of their surface originals: each is a Bergsonian gag whose punchline has been replaced by a threat. Peele has often remarked that comedy and horror share an architecture of tension and release, and Freud's *Jokes and Their Relation to the Unconscious* (1905) explains what is at stake in that architecture. The tendentious joke smuggles hostility past the censor and rewards its audience with a discharge of saved psychic expenditure. Peele's horror is the tendentious joke whose discharge has been withheld. The hostility is smuggled in; the release never comes; the audience is left holding the charge.

1.2 The Sketch Archive as Theory

Key & Peele (2012–2015) served as a laboratory in which the elements of the later cinema were isolated under comic conditions, and several sketches function as theoretical propositions in miniature.

The series' signature subject was code-switching: the continuous calibration of speech, posture, and affect by which a Black subject deputizes an acceptable self to negotiate a hostile environment. In a sketch that opened the first season, two men on cell phones, speaking to their wives in mild domestic registers, slide into exaggerated vernacular toughness upon noticing one another, then relax once the other has passed. The self is here a vicar of the self, dispatched to stand in where the person cannot safely appear. "Obama's Anger Translator," in which Peele's composed President is accompanied by Key's Luther, who voices the fury the President may not display, extends the logic to sovereignty itself. The first Black head of state must outsource his affect to a deputy, because the Black body in power cannot be seen to rage. Luther is, avant la lettre, Obama's Tethered: the double who performs, below the threshold of the acceptable, what the surface self must repress.

"Auction Block" stages two enslaved men who grow indignant that they are not being purchased while others are, and who undertake to advertise their own value. The joke lies in the internalization of the auction's metric, the captive's desire to be desired by the market that captures him. *Get Out*'s silent auction is its horrific reprise. "Negrotown" (2015) follows a Black man, stopped and beaten by police, as a mysterious elder leads him into a musical utopia free of profiling, harassment, and suspicion, before revealing the utopia as the hallucination of a concussed man in the back of a squad car. The fantasy of exit is shown to be a symptom of capture, anticipating both the Sunken Place, where consciousness floats in an elsewhere while the body is held, and the police lights that close *Get Out*. A further sketch, in which two men discover that the undead themselves observe the color line, compresses the premise of Peele's horror into a single conceit: the genre's monsters are racialized, and race determines whom they consume. "Substitute Teacher," finally, presents Mr. Garvey, whose name summons Marcus Garvey, an inner-city substitute who mangles the names of white suburban students while insisting upon the authority of his own phonetics. The sketch inverts the institutional mispronunciation of Black names; the roll call, Althusser's scene of interpellation in miniature, is seized by the substitute, who for once is sovereign.

1.3 The Comic Lineage: Pryor, Murphy, Chappelle

The sketches inherit a tradition of Black stand-up and sketch comedy as vernacular ethnography of whiteness and of the state. Richard Pryor's routines anatomized police violence and white anxiety with a candor that made the comic stage an instrument of testimony. Eddie Murphy's *Delirious* (1983) contains the routine that serves as the prehistory of Peele's first title: riffing on *The Amityville Horror* (1979), whose spectral voice commands a priest to

get out, Murphy observes that a Black family would obey the house at once, while white families in haunted-house films inexplicably stay. The imperative thereby migrates from the demon's mouth to the vernacular common sense of survival, and from there, in Peele, to the audience's own voice. Dave Chappelle's *Chappelle's Show* (2003–2006) supplied the most audacious precedent for Peele's interest in race as a regime of vision: Clayton Bigsby, a blind Black man raised to believe himself white who becomes a white-supremacist author, is the comic chiasmus of *Get Out*'s Jim Hudson, a blind white man who would purchase Black eyes. Where Bigsby demonstrates that race is a way of seeing imposed upon the sightless, Hudson demonstrates that whiteness covets the perception of those it has racialized.

1.4 *Keanu* and Blackness as Costume

In *Keanu* (2016), two middle-class Black men from the suburbs, Rell and Clarence, pass as hardened criminals to retrieve a stolen kitten, adopting the personas "Tectonic" and "Shark Tank" and converting Clarence's devotion to George Michael into gang-hall currency. The film treats Blackness as a wardrobe that can be worn, mis-sized, and swapped, and it locates the object of desire in the cute, which Sianne Ngai (2012) identified as the aesthetic of powerlessness, eliciting tenderness and aggression at once. *Get Out* reverses the costume. Andre Hayworth, reintroduced as "Logan King," appears in a straw boater beside a much older white wife, speaking in the stilted diction of a white elder: not a Black man performing a Blackness he lacks, but a white mind wearing a Black body it has seized.

1.5 Conjure and *Zonbi*: The Literal Turn in African American Gothic

The literalizing procedure has a lineage older than cinema. Charles W. Chesnutt's conjure tales, gathered in *The Conjure Woman* (1899), are narrated by Uncle Julius, a formerly enslaved man, to a white Northern entrepreneur who has bought a ruined plantation. In "Po' Sandy" (1888), an enslaved man perpetually hired out to distant plantations is transformed by his conjure-woman wife into a tree so that he may remain near her; the tree is felled and sawn into lumber for the master's new kitchen, which the dead man thereafter haunts. In "The Goophered Grapevine" (1887), an enslaved man bewitched by the master's vines waxes youthful each spring and withers each winter, so that the master sells him dear in the season of vigor and buys him back cheap in the season of decline. Chesnutt's conjure literalizes slavery's own metaphors: the enslaved as timber, as crop, as seasonal commodity. Its frame enacts what Mills would later call the epistemology of ignorance, for the white listener grasps nothing, while Julius deploys each tale toward material ends that the

listener never perceives. Chesnutt is the first great practitioner of what this dissertation calls Monkeypaw poetics.

The Haitian *zonbi* supplies the genealogy's other root. In its Caribbean origin the zombie is not a cannibal but a laborer: a body raised and set to work by a *bokor*, its will held captive, in the Vodou anthropology of the person, through the seizure of a component of the soul often identified as the *ti bon ange*. The figure condenses the enslaved person's nightmare of servitude extending beyond death, of a return to Guinea forever deferred. William Seabrook's *The Magic Island* (1929) carried it to the United States; Victor Halperin's *White Zombie* (1932), the first zombie feature, set Bela Lugosi's sorcerer over a sugar mill worked by the undead; Zora Neale Hurston's *Tell My Horse* (1938) recorded her encounter with Felicia Felix-Mentor, reputed to have returned from the grave. Romero's *Night of the Living Dead* severed the figure from its plantation origin and transformed it into the consuming horde. *Get Out* restores it. Walter and Georgina are *zonbi* in the strict Caribbean sense: bodies laboring under a will not their own, their persons held below. Where Halperin's title set a white woman at the center of the zombie plantation, Peele's first film discloses that the zombie was always Black and its bokor always white.

1.6 The Signifying Monkey

Henry Louis Gates Jr.'s *The Signifying Monkey* (1988) traced African American literary practice to two interlocking figures: Esu-Elegbara, the Yoruba trickster who stands at the crossroads as interpreter between gods and humans, and the Signifying Monkey of African American toasts. In the toast, the Monkey tells the Lion that the Elephant has insulted the Lion's family. The Lion, who reads literally, confronts the Elephant and is thrashed; the Monkey prevails because the Lion cannot distinguish figurative from literal speech. Signifyin(g), in Gates's formulation, is repetition with a signal difference, a double-voiced discourse (Gates draws on Bakhtin) that addresses two audiences at once and turns the powerful reader's literalism against him.

Peele's method inverts the toast while preserving its mechanism. Where the Monkey deceives the Lion by speaking figuratively to one who hears literally, Peele undoes the dominant culture by hearing literally what it intends figuratively. Its euphemisms ("post-racial," "we are all connected," "the spectacle consumes us") are granted their full literal content, and the Lion is made to face the Elephant of its own figures. The African diasporic trickster tradition supplies the rest of the method's repertoire. The Br'er Rabbit cycle, collected from Black storytellers and framed for white readers by Joel Chandler Harris in *Uncle Remus* (1880), is itself a monument to authorial vicarity, a Black oral tradition circulated under a white name. Anansi, the Akan spi-

der who purchased all stories from the sky god Nyame, crossed the Middle Passage and resurfaced as Neil Gaiman's Mr. Nancy. Peele's own decision to name his company for a monkey and a paw places him at the junction of these traditions: the trickster who signifies, and the talisman that literalizes.

1.7 Ellison's Mask and Dunbar's Debt

Ralph Ellison's "Change the Joke and Slip the Yoke" (1958), written in reply to Stanley Edgar Hyman's archetypal reading of the Black trickster, insisted that the minstrel mask was a white invention, a ritual in which white Americans projected onto a blackened face the anxieties they could not acknowledge as their own; the Black performer who wears the mask may nonetheless turn the ritual, changing the joke in order to slip the yoke. The essay names, with uncanny precision, the arc of Peele's career. The comedian whom audiences expected to wear the mask changed the joke into horror and thereby slipped the yoke of the genre's sacramental economy.

Paul Laurence Dunbar had given the mask its ledger in 1895:

> We wear the mask that grins and lies, / It hides our cheeks and shades our eyes,— / This debt we pay to human guile;

The grin is a debt, a payment exacted under the vicarious contract. Georgina's smile, the fixed rictus of the Tethered Umbrae, and the mask that Jason Wilson pulls down over his face in the final moments of *Us* are installments on that debt, and Peele's camera lingers on each as if auditing the account.

1.8 The Paw

W. W. Jacobs's "The Monkey's Paw" (1902) opens in a cottage where Mr. and Mrs. White and their son Herbert receive Sergeant-Major Morris, returned after twenty-one years of colonial service in India, who produces a mummified paw. "It had a spell put on it by an old fakir," he explains, "a very holy man. He wanted to show that fate ruled people's lives, and that those who interfered with it did so to their sorrow." At Herbert's prompting, Mr. White wishes for two hundred pounds to clear the debt on the house. The next day a representative of Maw and Meggins arrives: Herbert has been "caught in the machinery"; the firm disclaims liability but, in consideration of his services, offers compensation, and the sum is two hundred pounds. Mrs. White, deranged by grief, compels her husband to wish their son alive. Hours later, a knocking sounds at the door. As she fumbles at the bolt, Mr. White finds the paw and utters the third wish; the knocking ceases, and the door opens on an empty road.

Three features of the tale constitute the template this dissertation discerns in Peele. The first is literalism: the paw grants precisely what is said, by the most economical causal path available, and the horror lies in the gap between the wish's figurative intention and its literal fulfillment. The second is vicarity: every wish is paid for by a substitute. The son's body pays for the house; a thing that is no longer the son stands in for his return; the son's second death pays for the parents' peace. The third is colonial provenance: the paw is loot, empowered by the curse of a colonized holy man, and it returns to the metropole to punish a domestic economy built upon industrial machinery and imperial service. That the family is named White is the tale's most legible signifier and, for a reader after Peele, its most uncanny. Whatever the depth of Peele's investment in the allusion, the emblem he chose compresses the whole method: a monkey for the trickster who signifies, and a paw for the wish that is granted to the letter.

Jacobs's tale belongs to a Gothic family of wish-talismans that are, without exception, machines of vicarity. Balzac's *La Peau de chagrin* (1831) grants its owner's wishes while shrinking with each, so that every fulfillment is paid in the wisher's remaining life. Robert Louis Stevenson's "The Bottle Imp" (1891) grants every wish to its possessor but damns whoever dies holding it; it can be passed on only by sale, and only at a lower price than was paid. Damnation therefore flows down the economic ladder until it reaches someone too poor to sell it on. Stevenson's bottle is the purest literary model of the logic that *Us* will render geological: the cost of the surface's wishes descends, transaction by transaction, to those beneath.

1.9 Serling's Fable

The last tributary is Rod Serling's *The Twilight Zone* (1959–1964), which Peele revived as host and executive producer in 2019. Serling turned to the fantastic after sponsors gutted his teleplay "Noon on Doomsday" (1956), drawn from the murder of Emmett Till; the alien and the uncanny allowed him to say on network television what the realist drama could not. His fables ranged from the mass paranoia of "The Monsters Are Due on Maple Street" (1960) to the doppelgänger of "Mirror Image" (1960), which Peele has acknowledged as a seed of *Us*, and the culinary twist of "To Serve Man" (1962), in which an alien text promising humanity's welfare proves to be a cookbook. Serling bequeathed to Peele the moral fable's economy: a single premise, rigorously literalized, whose final turn returns the indictment to the viewer.

1.10 Monkeypaw Poetics Defined

The genealogy permits a formal definition. Monkeypaw poetics comprises five operations. First, *literalization*: a figure of speech or wish circulating in the dominant culture is granted its literal content (the post-racial becomes a Black body without a Black subject; national togetherness becomes a tether; the consuming spectacle becomes a predator that eats those who watch). Second, *double-voicing*: each element is addressed to divergent audiences who receive it differently, so that a single line may be comic across one side of the color line and menacing across the other. Third, *vicarious accounting*: every literalized wish is shown to be paid for by a substitute, and the narrative's labor consists in making the substitute visible and then canceling the debt. Fourth, *trickster survival*: the protagonist endures not through the Final Girl's endurance but through the trickster's improvisations, which turn the oppressor's literalism against him. Fifth, *generic signifyin(g)*: the canonical forms of white American horror, from the Stepford enclave and the Romero siege to the Spielbergian withheld monster, are repeated with a signal difference that discloses what they had excluded. The chapters that follow trace these operations through each film in turn.

2

Chapter Two

Everything but the Burden

Get Out *and Possessive Vicarity*

The light of the body is the eye: if therefore thine eye be single, thy whole body shall be full of light.

Matthew 6:22

Get Out enacts the first wish of the paw: compensation, the conversion of a body into value. Its subject is possessive vicarity, the master's desire to live in the substitute's body, to see through the substitute's eyes, to feel through the substitute's nerves, and to leave to the substitute the single possession the master does not want, which is the burden. Its hold is endopsychic, a cavity beneath the self; its arithmetic is two minds in one body; its Ovidian figure is Actaeon, the man transformed into prey who cannot say who he is.

2.1 The Liberal Estate

The Armitage estate is the American horror film's oldest stage, the isolated house, refurnished in the idiom of the post-racial liberal enclave. The father is a neurosurgeon who announces, unprompted, that he would have voted for Obama a third time; the mother is a psychiatrist who practices hypnosis; the Black groundskeeper and housekeeper are explained, with an awareness of optics that is itself part of the trap, as help retained out of loyalty to the late grandparents. Peele has acknowledged Ira Levin as a progenitor, and the debt is structural. In *The Stepford Wives* (Levin, 1972; Bryan Forbes, 1975), a suburban men's association replaces wives with compliant replicas; in *Rosemary's Baby* (Levin, 1967; Roman Polanski, 1968), solicitous elderly neighbors conceal a coven that requires a young woman's womb. Both novels expose a genteel social order whose courtesy is the surface of an appropriation program, and both locate the appropriation in the body of the one who is welcomed. *Guess Who's Coming to Dinner* (1967) supplies the comic template that Peele converts: a white liberal family receives its daughter's Black fiancé, a figure of such exemplary credentials that acceptance becomes a test of the parents' virtue rather than of his. In Peele's remake the parents pass the test with ease, because their acceptance is acquisitive. John Frankenheimer's *Seconds* (1966), in which a corporation sells aging men new bodies and new lives, contributes the commercial infrastructure of rebirth.

A further precedent clarifies by inversion. In Iain Softley's *The Skeleton Key* (2005), two Black servants lynched in Louisiana in the 1920s are revealed to have survived by transferring their souls, through hoodoo, into the bodies of the white children of the house, and to have continued migrating from white host to white host for decades. The film imagines body-transfer as Black survival through whiteness; *Get Out* imagines it as white survival through Blackness. The two films are mirror images, and the asymmetry of their reception, one a modest genre exercise, the other a phenomenon, measures how much more legible the second fantasy proved to be.

The garden party is the estate's rite. Its guests deliver the liberal grammar of racial admiration as a sequence of appraisals: a remark that Black is now in fashion, a boast of acquaintance with Tiger Woods, an inquiry into

Chris's physique and sexual prowess, and a question, from the only Asian guest, whether being African American is on balance an advantage or a disadvantage. Each compliment is a price. The guests embody what Mills called the epistemology of ignorance, but in a mode the concept did not quite anticipate: they are not ignorant of Blackness, which they have studied with a collector's attention, but ignorant of Black personhood, which their admiration is designed to make unnecessary.

2.2 The Coagula: Fungibility, Surgery, Alchemy

The procedure the Armitages administer has three phases: hypnotic preparation by the mother, neurosurgical transplantation by the father of the purchaser's brain into the captive's skull, and the consignment of a residue of the captive's consciousness to the Sunken Place, where it remains as witness. Its name is drawn from the alchemical maxim *solve et coagula*, dissolve and coagulate, which Éliphas Lévi inscribed on the forearms of his Baphomet (1856) and which summarizes the Great Work's passage through *nigredo* (blackening, putrefaction), *albedo* (whitening), and *rubedo* (reddening). The Coagula is an *albedo* performed upon a *nigredo*: a whitening of the black body that the alchemical imaginary would classify as purification. C. G. Jung's *Psychology and Alchemy* (1944) read the opus as an allegory of individuation, the integration of the self's opposites; the Armitages perform its racial parody, in which the white self achieves wholeness by incorporating the Black body it has dissolved.

Fungibility is the procedure's economic premise. Hartman's account of the captive body as an empty vessel for others' projected desires, and Spillers's distinction between the body, a social and legal person, and the flesh, the prior and violated substance upon which captivity writes its hieroglyphics, find here their most literal cinematic rendering. The surgical theater in the Armitage basement condenses a medical history that Harriet A. Washington's *Medical Apartheid* (2006) documents in detail: J. Marion Sims's experimental gynecological surgeries upon enslaved women in the 1840s; the United States Public Health Service syphilis study at Tuskegee (1932–1972); the cells taken from Henrietta Lacks without consent in 1951 and commercialized as the HeLa line. That the household unites a neurosurgeon and a psychiatrist, the twin authorities over body and mind, is the film's most exact sociological detail. Medicine's racial history appears as a family business.

The Coagula's origin story binds it to eugenics. The grandfather, Roman Armitage, lost to Jesse Owens in a qualifying race for the 1936 Berlin Olympics, the Games at which Owens's four gold medals embarrassed the racial science of the host regime. The family's response to Owens is not the repudiation of Black superiority but its harvest. I call this *eugenic appropriation*: a eugenics

that does not eliminate the superior other but appropriates him, mining the bodies it has ranked for the capacities it envies. Roman lives on inside the groundskeeper Walter, sprinting across the lawn at night in a body that will never lose to Owens again. The defeated racer at last wins his race, in a stolen body.

The film's prologue establishes the predation. Andre Hayworth, lost at night in a white suburb, an inversion of the white protagonist lost in a dangerous neighborhood, is shadowed by a white sports car whose stereo plays the 1939 music-hall song "Run Rabbit Run." The title names him as game. The rabbit, introduced here as prey, will return in *Us* as food, as sign, and as experimental subject.

2.3 Love and Theft: Everything but the Burden

Eric Lott's *Love and Theft* (1993) read blackface minstrelsy as the expression of a white working-class desire at once attracted to and expropriative of Black culture, enacted through the mask. Norman Mailer's "The White Negro" (1957) celebrated the hipster as a white man who absorbs the existential intensity he attributes to Black life. Michael Rogin's *Blackface, White Noise* (1996) showed blackface serving as the vehicle by which immigrants purchased their admission to whiteness. Greg Tate's anthology *Everything but the Burden* (2003) gave the tradition its most incisive title: white America wants everything Black culture produces except the burden of being Black.

Get Out literalizes this genealogy with surgical exactitude. The Coagula grants the purchaser everything (the body, the strength, the youth, the eyes, the cool) except the burden, which is retained by the sunken consciousness that goes on bearing, in silence, the condition of Blackness. Frantz Fanon's *Black Skin, White Masks* (1952) diagnosed the colonized subject compelled to wear whiteness as a mask over Black skin. The Coagula manufactures the chiasmus of Fanon's title: a white mind behind a Black face, the face itself become the mask.

BlacKkKlansman (2018), which Peele produced, completes a diptych of vicarious identity. In Spike Lee's film, the Black detective Ron Stallworth lends his voice by telephone to a white-supremacist organization, while his white, Jewish colleague Flip Zimmerman lends his body to Stallworth's name in person. Voice and body are exchanged across the color line in the service of infiltration. *Get Out* inverts the exchange in the service of possession: a white mind takes a Black body, and the Black voice is silenced below.

2.4 The Auction

At the party's climax, Dean Armitage stands beside an easel bearing Chris's photograph while the guests, in silence, raise bingo cards. The slave auction is transposed into the genteel genre of the charity auction, and the winner is the blind art dealer Jim Hudson. Hartman's *Scenes of Subjection* devotes a chapter to the "innocent amusements" of slavery: the coerced singing and dancing of coffles on their way to market and of enslaved people on display, staged as evidence of contentment and therefore of slavery's benignity. Georgina's and Walter's cheer is this coerced merriment rendered as possession. The servants are not merely made to perform contentment; they are inhabited by those who demand it.

Georgina condenses the history of coerced surrogacy that Delores Williams placed at the center of womanist theology and that Patricia Hill Collins (1990) analyzed through the controlling image of the mammy. A white grandmother occupies a young Black woman's body so as to remain at the center of the kitchen and of the family she presides over. The mammy who is said to be "like family" is here literally the family's matriarch, and the surrogate body is the instrument by which white maternal authority survives its own death. When Chris apologizes for having seemed to report her to Rose, Georgina answers with a stammered cascade of refusals while a tear runs down the smiling face: the sunken woman surfacing through the occupant's composure, the debt of Dunbar's mask paid out in a single drop.

2.5 The Eye: Second-Sight as Commodity

W. E. B. Du Bois wrote in 1903 that "the Negro is a sort of seventh son, born with a veil, and gifted with second-sight in this American world," and he named the cost of the gift "this double-consciousness, this sense of always looking at one's self through the eyes of others." Chris Washington is a photographer: his profession is second-sight. Jim Hudson, who wins him at auction, explains that he is indifferent to Chris's race; he wants Chris's eye, the faculty that sees what others miss. Hudson is the most liberal of the bidders and the most chilling, because his desire is directed at the most intimate possession of all: perception itself. He wants Du Bois's gift without Du Bois's veil.

Hudson inverts the Theban seer. Ovid's Tiresias is blinded by Juno and granted prophecy by Jupiter in compensation; Hudson, blind, would purchase sight from the one whom the world has made a seer by making him suffer. His desire also recapitulates the founding text of the uncanny. In Hoffmann's "Der Sandmann," a barometer-seller hawks eyes, the hero dreads their theft, and the beloved automaton is revealed to have no eyes

of her own; Freud's reading of the tale made the fear of losing one's eyes the paradigm of uncanny dread. *Get Out* is the Sandman's racial reprise: an automaton (Georgina, preening before her reflection in a window), an eye-merchant (Hudson), and a hero whose eyes are coveted by a market in perception.

The camera flash is the film's counter-instrument. When Chris photographs Andre, now "Logan King," the flash ruptures the hypnosis. Andre surfaces for a moment, nose bleeding, and lunges at Chris, screaming that he must get out: the title's first utterance in the diegesis, delivered by the trapped self in the voice of the audience. The camera, instrument of the seer, becomes the instrument of exorcism. Simone Browne (2015) named *dark sousveillance* the appropriation by the surveilled of the technologies of surveillance for the purposes of escape; Chris's flash is its exemplary instance, and he will use it again to free Walter, who turns the rifle first on Rose and then on himself.

2.6 Actaeon, the Deer, and the Buck

Ovid tells how Actaeon, hunting with his hounds, stumbled upon Diana bathing, how she flung water in his face and transformed him into a stag, and how, as his own pack closed in, he longed to cry out:

> *"Actaeon ego sum: dominum cognoscite vestrum!" / verba animo desunt.* (Met. III.230–231)
>
> "I am Actaeon: know your master!" But words fail his mind.

The Sunken Place's prisoner is Actaeon: a man transformed, in the eyes of the world, into another thing, unable to declare himself, watching the instruments of his former life turned against him. Andre's outburst under the flash is the moment Actaeon's words do not fail, and it lasts only seconds.

The deer runs through the film as the Actaeon motif's material trace. Rose strikes a deer on the drive, and Chris walks into the woods to watch it die, because his mother died alone by a roadside after a hit-and-run while he, a child, sat paralyzed before a television. Dean declares his loathing for the local deer and his wish to see them exterminated, in the demographic idiom of infestation that racist discourse reserves for unwanted populations. A buck's head is mounted in the basement where Chris is held. Donald Bogle's *Toms, Coons, Mulattoes, Mammies, and Bucks* (1973) named the "brutal black buck" as the stereotype D. W. Griffith's *The Birth of a Nation* (1915) enshrined, the Black man as sexual and physical menace. Chris kills Dean with the mounted buck's antlers. The stereotype's weaponry is turned against its author, and the hunted stag, at last, gores the hunter.

2.7 The Sunken Place: Apparatus, Hold, Zone of Nonbeing

Missy's silver spoon circles the rim of her teacup, she summons the memory of the mother's death, and Chris sinks: first into his armchair, then through it, into an infinite black void, where he floats, gazing up at a receding rectangle of light in which he sees, as on a distant screen, whatever his eyes see. Peele glossed the image in 2017 as a figure of marginalization, a place where the system silences the scream however loud it may be. The image sustains three superimposed readings.

The first is apparatus-theoretical. Plato's cave (*Republic* VII) confines prisoners from childhood before a wall of shadows. Jean-Louis Baudry (1970; 1975) argued that the cinema reproduces the cave: the immobilized spectator in darkness before a luminous rectangle, regressing toward a dreamlike state, identifying, as Christian Metz (1977) added, first and above all with the camera's all-perceiving eye. The Sunken Place is the cinema as apparatus theory described it, with its ideological pleasure stripped away. The buyer's explanation removes all doubt: the residue of Chris will remain below as a passenger, an audience. Chris's founding trauma is spectatorial. He watched television while his mother died, and the hypnosis exploits that paralysis. The Sunken Place generalizes the scene into a sentence: the Black subject condemned to watch his own life as television. The audience of *Get Out* occupies the structural position of the sunken subject, watching Chris's life on a screen, unable to act, and the film thereby turns its own apparatus into an accusation. The cinema seat is the Sunken Place's twin, and Peele makes every spectator feel the paralysis that classical cinema sold as pleasure.

The second reading is maritime. The Sunken Place lies below decks: it is the hold, Sharpe's figure of the captive's transport, reimagined as psychic interior. The subject falls downward into oceanic darkness; he is, in the literal sense of the word, sunk. The *Zong*'s jettisoned and the Middle Passage's drowned haunt the image's vertical axis.

The third is phenomenological. Fanon's introduction to *Black Skin, White Masks* describes a zone of nonbeing, sterile and arid, a stripped declivity, and adds that in this zone an authentic upheaval may be born. Orlando Patterson's social death is constituted by natal alienation, the severance of the enslaved from ancestry and kin; Missy sinks Chris through the memory of his mother, so that natal alienation becomes hypnotic technique. Ralph Ellison's invisible narrator, underground in a hole blazing with 1,369 stolen light bulbs, is visible to himself and invisible to all; the Sunken Place inverts the figure into total darkness, in which the subject sees everything and is seen by no one.

2.8

Circe, the Sirens, and the Rowers

The hypnosis rehearses the *Odyssey*. Missy is Circe, whose potion in a cup transforms men into beasts for her use; her spoon against the porcelain is the Sirens' song, sound as weapon. Max Horkheimer and Theodor W. Adorno, in *Dialectic of Enlightenment* (1944/1947), read the Sirens episode as the primal scene of the bourgeois division between art and labor: Odysseus, bound to the mast, hears the song as aesthetic experience but cannot act upon it, while his rowers, their ears stopped with wax, labor in deafness. The episode is the archetype of vicarity: the rowers labor so that the master may enjoy the song in safety. Peele's revision is exact. Strapped into the armchair in the basement, Chris tears stuffing from its armrest and plugs his ears, rendering himself deaf to the spoon as the rowers were to the Sirens. The stuffing is cotton. Chris picks cotton to save himself: the commodity whose cultivation organized slavery's economy becomes the earplug of liberation. The rower refuses the master's song, and in doing so wins back his hands.

The Cyclops episode supplies a further gloss. Odysseus escapes Polyphemus by calling himself *Outis*, Nobody. The Coagula's object is to make Chris Nobody, so that another may become somebody in his body. The single coveted eye, the blinded giant, and the cunning victim who survives by manipulating names form a constellation that the film activates without citing.

2.9

Rod as Cassandra

Rod Williams, the Transportation Security Administration officer who keeps Chris's dog, deduces the truth: abduction, hypnosis, enslavement. When he takes his theory to the police, three detectives, one of them a Black woman, laugh him out of the room. Rod is Cassandra, cursed by Apollo to prophesy truly and never to be believed. Peele's insight is that in American public discourse comedy is the register in which truth may be spoken precisely because it will not be credited. Rod is also the film's vernacular state: the lowest rung of the security apparatus, a functionary of airport screening, is the only officer of any kind who acts on behalf of the Black subject.

2.10

The Endings and the Wish

In the released ending, Chris, having escaped, is strangling the wounded Rose when a car with flashing lights approaches. For a long beat the film lets its audience, above all its Black audience, anticipate the arrest that would complete Chris's capture under another name. The car is Rod's airport-security vehicle, and Chris is driven away. The ending originally shot, preserved on the home release, concludes with Chris's arrest and a prison visit from Rod;

Peele has indicated that the change answered the needs of the film's moment. An Afropessimist reading in the line of Wilderson would hold the original ending to be structurally truthful, the escape from the plantation merely a transfer to the carceral state that Michelle Alexander (2010) named the New Jim Crow, and the released ending a consoling fantasy.

I propose a different account. The released ending is the director's wish granted to his audience, and it is marked as a wish. The rescue arrives in a car whose markings mimic the police, driven by the state's most comic avatar, and the film forces us to undergo the original ending's dread for a full beat before converting it into relief. The released ending thus contains the original as its shadow. It is, moreover, the film's purest instance of bifocal address. As the lights approach, Rose calls out for help, performing the white victimhood that Ruby Hamad (2018) analyzed as a weapon; for one spectator the lights mean rescue, for another they mean doom, and the same image is received in opposite registers across the color line until the comic reversal reunites them.

2.11 Compensation: The First Wish

Get Out enacts Jacobs's first wish. The Armitages' desire to cheat decline, blindness, and death is compensated by the purchase of Black bodies, and the auction price is the compensation; as in Jacobs, the body pays. The film's arithmetic is two minds in one body. Its hold is endopsychic. Its Ovidian figure is Actaeon, joined by an inverted Tiresias. Its speech act is the imperative, a warning issued from outside the frame by an audience that can see what the protagonist cannot. And its breach of the vicarious contract is the substitute's refusal to remain compensation: the rower who stops his ears, the stag who gores the hunter, the photographer who turns the flash upon the possessors. The first wish is canceled by the one who was to have paid for it.

3

Chapter Three

The Shadow Ledger

Us *and Reciprocal Vicarity*

So the last shall be first, and the first last.

Matthew 20:16

Us enacts the second wish of the paw: return. What the nation buried knocks at the door at night, and it proves to be the household itself. Its subject is reciprocal vicarity, in which the substitute lives the master's life below in degraded mimicry, bearing its costs, while the master enjoys its benefits above in ignorance. Its hold is chthonic; its arithmetic is one soul in two bodies; its Ovidian figure is Narcissus, flanked by Tiresias's prophecy and Cadmus's earthborn warriors; its speech act is the deictic pronoun, whose referent shifts with whoever speaks it.

3.1 *Us*, U.S.

The title is a pun on the national abbreviation, and the film's most quoted line seals it: asked what they are, the intruders' leader answers, "We're Americans." The first-person plural is a deictic, a word whose reference depends upon its speaker, and *Us* exploits the instability of the national "we" until the opposition between "us" and "them" collapses into an opposition between "us" and "us." Peele framed the film's casting as a deliberate universalization. A Black family occupies the center of a horror film simply as a family; *Get Out*, he said, had proved that everything is about race, *Us* that not everything is, and he added, with a showman's relish, "I've proved both points!" (*Rolling Stone*, recalling its 2019 interview). This chapter argues that the two points are one, and that vicarity is the concept that unifies them.

The Wilsons have climbed. They own a lake house near Santa Cruz, a car, and, by the film's first act, a secondhand boat purchased in a spirit of rivalry with their white friends the Tylers, whose larger boat, cocktails, smart speaker, and cosmetic surgeries set the standard the Wilsons chase. Thorstein Veblen's *The Theory of the Leisure Class* (1899) named this dynamic "invidious comparison": consumption as a ranking device whose satisfactions are relative and therefore insatiable. The American Dream appears in *Us* as a ladder of envy. The Tethered are its underside.

3.2 Jeremiah 11:11 and the Broken Covenant

In the 1986 prologue a homeless man on the Santa Cruz boardwalk holds a placard reading "Jeremiah 11:11," and the numerals recur throughout the film, on clocks, on scoreboards, in the doubled verticals of the date. The verse reads: "Therefore thus saith the LORD, Behold, I will bring evil upon them, which they shall not be able to escape; and though they shall cry unto me, I will not hearken unto them." Its context is decisive and has gone largely unremarked. Jeremiah 11 concerns a covenant made when God brought Israel "forth out of the land of Egypt, from the iron furnace" (11:4): a covenant of liberated slaves, whose breach brings a curse upon every party who "obeyeth

not the words of this covenant" (11:3). The film's epigraph therefore points to a broken contract whose original signatories were freed captives, and whose breach summons an evil from which there is no escape and to which no authority will respond. The American analogue is a nation founded on a covenant of liberty that rested upon bondage, and the vicarious contract is that covenant's hidden schedule of payments.

The promised non-response is staged with precision. No police arrive in *Us*. When Kitty Tyler, under attack, commands her smart speaker, named Ophelia, to call the police, the device instead plays N.W.A's 1988 anthem against police violence, a gag of Monkeypaw literalism in which a machine hears the instruction to its letter and returns the culture's own curse. The state that created the Tethered does not hearken.

The palindrome 11:11 is a mirror number, a pair of pairs, two upright figures and their reflections. Its visual rhyme is the film's governing historical image, Hands Across America, staged on 25 May 1986, when millions of Americans attempted to form a human chain across the continent to raise funds against hunger and homelessness. The event was a corporate-sponsored spectacle of solidarity, and young Adelaide watches its commercial in the film's first shot. In the film's last, the Tethered, clad in red and holding hands, form their own chain across the hills. The paw grants the nation's wish for unity to the letter: the hungry and homeless for whom the chain was formed now form it themselves, and the charitable spectacle becomes its beneficiaries' insurrection. The image carries a second, older resonance. A line of linked bodies stretching across the land is also a coffle, the chained file in which captives were driven overland to market, and Peele's final shot holds the charity and the coffle in a single frame.

3.3 One Soul in Two Bodies

The opening title card informs us that thousands of miles of tunnels run beneath the continental United States, abandoned subways, disused service routes, deserted mine shafts, many with no known purpose. Red's monologue supplies the purpose. An unspecified government created the Tethered to control the people above. It could copy bodies but not souls; the soul remained one, shared between two. When the experiment failed, the copies were abandoned below, compelled to mimic in the dark every movement of their originals: eating raw rabbit when the originals dined, marrying in grotesque parody when they married, bearing children they did not want when they bore children they did.

The arithmetic inverts *Get Out*'s. Where the Coagula installs two minds in one body, the Tethered distribute one soul across two bodies, and the distribution is radically unequal: one body enjoys the soul's life, the other bears

its costs. The Tethered are the externalized costs of surface life, its labor, poverty, confinement, and bodily ruin, rendered as persons. Ruth Wilson Gilmore's *Golden Gulag* (2007) named "organized abandonment" the political economy by which states withdraw from populations rendered surplus and then confine them; she defined racism as the state-sanctioned or extralegal production and exploitation of group-differentiated vulnerability to premature death. The abandoned experiment literalizes the first formulation and enacts the second. Michael Harrington's *The Other America* (1962) had described a poverty invisible to the affluent because it lay off the routes they traveled; Jacob Riis's *How the Other Half Lives* (1890) had made the tenement's interior a spectacle for those above. Du Bois's *Black Reconstruction* (1935) identified the "public and psychological wage" by which white workers were compensated for their exploitation with racial standing. The state experiment evokes MKUltra (1953–1973) and Tuskegee: the government's long record of operations upon populations that did not consent and were not told. Stevenson's bottle imp, sold always downward, has found its geology.

The Tethered's mimicry has a further, theoretical dimension. Linda Williams described horror as a body genre in which the spectator's body involuntarily imitates the bodies onscreen. The Tethered are spectators of the surface, whose lives constitute the show, condemned to imitate without the pleasure of spectatorship and without its exemption. They are the audience of the American spectacle, sentenced to mime it in the dark.

3.4 The Cave Inverted, the Philosopher Below

Plato's allegory confines its prisoners from childhood before a wall on which they see only the shadows of objects carried behind them; a prisoner freed and dragged up into the sun would, returning to liberate the others, be ridiculed and, could they lay hands on him, killed. The *Republic* opens with Socrates' first word, *katébēn*, "I went down." *Us* inverts and redistributes the allegory. The Tethered are the cave's prisoners, but they are not watching shadows: they are the shadows, bodied, cast by the surface people whose movements they must reproduce. The one who went down is Red, the original Adelaide, dragged below in 1986. She becomes the cave's philosopher, the only one of its inhabitants to have known the sun, and she does not ascend to the Good. She organizes the ascent of the others toward the surface's goods. Her dance, performed below in mirror of the surface girl's ballet recital, is read by the Tethered as a sign, and she becomes their prophet and the founder of a counter-republic.

Fanon supplies the political theory the allegory lacks. *The Wretched of the Earth* (1961) defines decolonization as the replacement of one species of men by another, the realization of the scriptural promise that the last shall be first.

The Tethered uprising is decolonization in Fanon's literal sense: not reform of the surface but substitution for it, each double killing its original in order to occupy its place. The film's horror is that decolonization, seen from the surface, looks exactly like a home invasion. And Fanon's zone of nonbeing, the arid declivity in which an authentic upheaval may be born, here becomes a subterranean nation from which an upheaval is born.

3.5 Inanna's Descent: The Law of Substitution

The Sumerian *Descent of Inanna*, composed early in the second millennium BCE, tells how Inanna, Queen of Heaven, descends to the Great Below ruled by her sister Ereshkigal. At each of seven gates she is stripped of a garment and an emblem of power; arriving naked before her sister, she is struck by the eye of death, and her corpse is hung upon a hook. Revived through the intervention of the god Enki, she may not leave the underworld without providing a substitute. Demons escort her through the world above; she spares those who mourned her and surrenders her husband Dumuzi, whom she finds enthroned and unmourning. Dumuzi's sister Geshtinanna offers to share his term, so that each spends half the year below.

Us restages the myth with the sisters exchanged. A girl from below seizes the place above, and the girl from above becomes, perforce, queen of the underworld. The myth's law, that no one leaves the Great Below without leaving someone in her place, is the film's economic law: every life above is purchased with a life below. Red's "once upon a time," recited to the captive family in their own living room, is the underworld queen's account of the law, delivered to those who have benefited from it without knowing its terms. Ereshkigal's eye of death, meanwhile, anticipates the lethal gaze that *Nope* will raise into the sky.

3.6 Andersen's Shadow and the Literary Double

Otto Rank's *Der Doppelgänger* (1914), which Freud absorbed into "The Uncanny," argued that the double begins as an insurance against the destruction of the ego, an energetic denial of death, and becomes, once that primitive narcissism is surmounted, the uncanny harbinger of death. The literary double accumulates around this reversal. Poe's "William Wilson" (1839) kills his double and thereby himself. Dostoevsky's *The Double* (1846) presents a clerk displaced by a successful replica who usurps his social position, the double as class rival. Stevenson's *Strange Case of Dr Jekyll and Mr Hyde* (1886) externalizes the repressed. Wilde's *The Picture of Dorian Gray* (1890) offers the purest pre-cinematic model of reciprocal vicarity: the portrait bears, in Dorian's stead, the deformations of his life, while the original enjoys an im-

munity that is the image's suffering transferred. The Tethered are Dorian's portrait, locked in the attic of the continent.

Hans Christian Andersen's "The Shadow" (1847) is the film's most exact literary template. A scholar's shadow detaches and departs; years later it returns, rich and polished, while the scholar has grown poor; the scholar consents to travel as his former shadow's shadow; the shadow marries a princess, and when the scholar threatens to reveal the truth, the shadow has him declared mad and executed. *Us* is Andersen's tale with its secret withheld until the end: the "Adelaide" we have followed is the shadow who became the person, "Red" is the person consigned to the shadow's place, and the shadow kills her to keep the secret. Andersen's tale ends with the shadow's triumph. So does Peele's. Rod Serling's "Mirror Image" (1960), in which a woman at a bus depot encounters a double resolved to replace her, a source Peele has acknowledged, supplies the American television idiom.

Jacques Lacan's mirror stage (1949) describes the infant's jubilant assumption of its specular image as an ideal unity, a misrecognition, *méconnaissance*, that founds the ego as alienated in an image that is other. In the 1986 hall of mirrors, young Adelaide confronts her reflection, and it proves to be not a reflection but another girl. Lacan's thesis becomes plot: the ego is the image that took the subject's place. "Adelaide" is, in the strict sense, an *imago*, the specular image that became the I. Homi K. Bhabha's analysis of colonial mimicry (1984) completes the theoretical frame: the colonized mimic is "almost the same, but not quite," and the slippage between resemblance and menace turns mimicry into mockery. The Tethered's gestures are almost the same, but not quite, and their imitation is a threat.

Red's voice condenses the history of the substitution. Lupita Nyong'o gives her a strangled rasp, the voice of one who was choked: in 1986 the Tethered girl throttled the original Adelaide before dragging her below, and the original's voice bears the injury ever after. Ovid's Echo, punished by Juno, can repeat only the last words of others and wastes away until nothing remains of her but voice. The Tethered communicate by grunt and gesture; only Red speaks, in a voice damaged at the moment of substitution, the one surface-born throat in the underworld.

3.7 Narcissus and Tiresias: "Find Yourself"

In the third book of the *Metamorphoses*, Tiresias is asked whether the infant Narcissus will live to old age and replies, *si se non noverit*: "if he does not come to know himself" (III.348). Years later Narcissus, gazing into a pool, at last understands: *iste ego sum: sensi, nec me mea fallit imago*, "I am he! I have perceived it; my image does not deceive me" (III.463). The recognition kills him. The hall of mirrors on the Santa Cruz beach advertises itself with

Tiresias's forbidden imperative: "Find Yourself." Young Adelaide's finding of herself in 1986 is the fatal self-knowledge the seer warned against, and the film's twist is Narcissus's *iste ego sum*, the recognition, by the woman we have followed and by the audience that followed her, that she is the image.

Tiresias's prophecy is the epigraph of the American Dream. One survives on the surface only by not knowing oneself, by not knowing what one's life costs below. Mills's epistemology of ignorance here acquires a Theban formulation: ignorance is the condition of longevity, and self-knowledge is lethal.

The attraction's names deepen the reading. In 1986 it is "Shaman Vision Quest," adorned with a caricatured Indigenous figure; by the film's present it has been renamed for Merlin and redecorated as a European wizard's forest. An appropriated Indigenous rite, the vision quest, has been sanitized into a Celtic fantasy without ceasing to be a commodity. The Santa Cruz coast is the homeland of Ohlone peoples, and the renaming registers, in the vernacular of a seaside amusement, the settler-colonial unconscious of the national "us." Eve Tuck and K. Wayne Yang's warning that "decolonization is not a metaphor" (2012) applies with force to any reading that converts the Tethered into an allegory of dispossession, and the film's own attention to the attraction's renaming suggests that it knows the ground upon which its pronoun stands.

3.8 Cadmus, the Sown Men, and Autochthony

Ovid's Theban book opens with Cadmus, who slays the serpent of Mars and, at Minerva's instruction, sows its teeth. Armed men spring from the furrows. When Cadmus reaches for his weapons, one of the earthborn cries out that he must not meddle in their civil wars (*nec te civilibus insere bellis*, III.117), and they slaughter one another until five remain to help him build the city. Claude Lévi-Strauss's "The Structural Study of Myth" (1955) read the Theban cycle as a logical instrument for mediating a contradiction between the belief that humans are autochthonous, born from the earth, and the knowledge that they are born of a man and a woman: the slaying of chthonic monsters denies autochthony, while the lame-footed names of the Labdacids (Labdacus, Laius, Oedipus) affirm its persistence.

Us is an American Theban myth in Lévi-Strauss's sense. The Tethered are earthborn doubles springing from the ground beneath the nation, and the contradiction the film mediates is the question of who is native to the land: the "we" that claims the continent as its own, as if born from it, against the "we" that arrived by conquest and settlement. The earthborn rise to dispute the surface's claim to autochthony, and the result is what Ovid's sown man named it, a civil war. Even Lévi-Strauss's fourth column finds an echo in the Tethered's halting, belated gait, part of a preoccupation with locomotion that

runs from Walter's nocturnal sprint through Zora Wilson's track training to the galloping horse of *Nope*.

3.9 Scissors, Rabbits, Gloves

Each Tethered carries gold scissors. The Moirai spin, measure, and cut the thread of life, and Atropos's shears are the instrument of the last of these acts. The Tethered's scissors sever the tether, the cord of shared soul, and the severance is also an umbilical cut: the uprising is a monstrous birth into the surface world. The scissors are, moreover, an emblem of the film's metaphysics, two identical blades joined at a pivot, each useless without the other.

The rabbits that line the underground's corridors in the credit sequence, and that the Tethered eat raw, gather several genealogies. Br'er Rabbit, the trickster of African American folklore who survives by cunning, appears here caged and consumed, the trickster imprisoned. Lewis Carroll's White Rabbit leads Alice down a hole into an underworld, and *Through the Looking-Glass* (1871) sends her through a mirror into an inverted world. The laboratory rabbit names the experiment. The rabbit's fecundity names the population that multiplies below. And the rabbit links back to *Get Out*'s prologue, where a song bade Andre run, rabbit, run: the prey of the first film becomes the food of the second.

In 1986 young Adelaide wins a Michael Jackson *Thriller* T-shirt on the boardwalk and wears it into the hall of mirrors; the Tethered wear red jumpsuits and a single glove. Jackson's *Thriller* video (1983) staged the transformation of the most-watched Black performer of the decade into a werecat and a zombie dancing before a global audience, and Jackson's own body became, over the following decade, the era's most visible figure of a Black body transformed under the gaze. The Tethered are dressed as *Thriller*'s dancers: the underground's uniform is the costume of the most celebrated Black performance of the surface's spectacle. The Wilson son, Jason, wears a *Jaws* shirt on the same beach, invoking the summer of 1975 and the predator beneath the surface. The VHS tapes stacked beside the television in the opening shot complete the coded prophecy: among them *C.H.U.D.* (1984), whose title abbreviates "cannibalistic humanoid underground dwellers," and *The Man with Two Brains* (1983), a title that could serve as *Get Out*'s logline.

3.10 Carnival and the Shore

The Santa Cruz Beach Boardwalk is a seaside amusement park, which is to say the Lucretian shore equipped with machinery. The family stands on the beach and watches the sea; beneath them run the tunnels. Mikhail Bakhtin's *Rabelais and His World* (1965) described carnival as the festive inversion of hierarchy,

the crowning of the fool, the triumph of the lower bodily stratum; carnival is licensed and therefore temporary, and its inversions return the world to order when the festival ends. The Tethered uprising is a carnival that refuses to end, a permanent crowning of the lower stratum, its participants in festival red. The amusement park is the built form of recreational terror, its rides engineered to simulate danger safely; *Us* opens in that architecture and lets the danger out.

3.11 *Fort/Da* and the Nation's Repetition

In *Beyond the Pleasure Principle* (1920), Freud describes his grandson throwing a wooden reel attached to a string over the edge of his cot with a drawn-out *o-o-o-o* (*fort*, gone) and pulling it back with a joyful *da* (there), mastering his mother's absences by staging them. The reel on its string is a tethered object, and the Tethered are *fort/da* in flesh: the nation masters what it has thrown away by keeping it tied below, at once gone and there. Their compulsory mimicry is the nation's repetition compulsion. Michael Abels's score transforms the Luniz's "I Got 5 on It" (1995), a song about pooling money to share the cost of a purchase, into a horror cue. The economics of the share become sinister: the question the song's title raises is who pays for whose portion.

3.12 The Twist as Oedipus; the Politics of *Us*

The twist reveals that in 1986 the Tethered girl throttled the original Adelaide, chained her below, and took her place; the muteness her parents attributed to shock was a girl from underground learning to speak, to dance, to pass. The structure is Oedipal in the strict Sophoclean sense: the defender of the household is the source of the plague, and anagnorisis is self-indictment. In the final shot, Jason, who has watched his mother kill Red with a savage efficiency, glances at her and pulls his mask down over his face. The son chooses the mask, Dunbar's grinning mask, and the debt it pays passes to the next generation.

The critical debate over *Us* has turned upon whether it abandons race for class. An Afropessimist objection in the line of Wilderson would hold that the analogy "we are all tethered" dissolves the structural singularity of antiblackness into a national allegory available to anyone, and that the film's universalism is a retreat. Peele's own framing, that *Get Out* proved everything is about race and *Us* that not everything is, invites the objection.

I propose that vicarity dissolves the impasse. Vicarity is a structure, not an identity: its positions are transferable, and that transferability is precisely what makes it a contract rather than a nature. Race is the historical name of the substitute position, the position into which the Atlantic world first and

most systematically consigned bodies, but the contract can enroll new signatories without abolishing the position. The Wilsons, a Black family that has reached the shore, have acquired a shadow. The twist intensifies the point, for Adelaide herself is a former substitute who seized the surface and became a beneficiary of the structure that had consigned her below. *Us* thus asks a question *Get Out* could not: what happens when the historically substituted reach the shore? The answer is that they acquire Tethered of their own unless the structure itself is dismantled. This is not a retreat from race but its generalization into a theory of positions, and it explains why a Black family is the film's necessary protagonist. Only a family whose ancestors occupied the hold can make visible that the shore is a position into which anyone may be drafted, and which anyone, once drafted, will kill to defend. Both of Peele's points are proved at once, because both are moments of a single argument.

3.13 Return: The Second Wish

In Jacobs's tale the second wish brings a knocking at the door in the night, and the family discovers that what has returned is not what they wished for. In *Us*, four figures holding hands appear in the Wilsons' driveway after dark and come to the door. Robin Wood's return of the repressed becomes the return of the substitute. Freud borrowed from Schelling a definition of the uncanny as that which ought to have remained secret and hidden but has come to light; *Us* renders the definition geological, as the hidden emerges from beneath the ground. The nation's wish for unity, for its other half to be gathered in, is granted as the return of what was buried, and the return takes the form not of reconciliation but of replacement.

The second wish's arithmetic is one soul in two bodies; its hold is chthonic; its Ovidian figure is Narcissus, with Tiresias's prophecy as epigraph and Cadmus's sown men as chorus; its speech act is the deictic, which enrolls every spectator in the "us" that has a shadow. Its breach of the vicarious contract is the substitutes' refusal to remain below, and its irony is that the breach is incomplete. The surviving "Adelaide" is a substitute who has become a master, and the second wish, like Jacobs's, is canceled only by the death of what returned. The debt is not discharged. It is inherited, behind a mask.

4

Chapter Four

Gazingstock

Nope *and Spectacular Vicarity*

The eye is not satisfied with seeing, nor the ear filled with hearing.

Ecclesiastes 1:8

Nope enacts the third wish of the paw: expulsion, the thing sent back whence it came. Its subject is spectacular vicarity, the regime in which the image of another's peril, extracted from expendable bodies (a jockey, a chimpanzee, a horse, a child actor, a wrangler), is sold to spectators at a remove, until the spectacle, grown autonomous, devours its audience. Its hold is ouranic, a predator concealed in weather; its arithmetic is one eye with no interior, swallowing a multitude; its Ovidian figure is Semele, incinerated by the epiphany she demanded, attended by Actaeon and countered by Perseus and Orpheus; its speech act is negation.

4.1 Nahum 3:6: The Bloody City and the Gazingstock

The epigraph is drawn from the prophet Nahum's oracle against Nineveh, capital of the Assyrian empire: "And I will cast abominable filth upon thee, and make thee vile, and will set thee as a gazingstock" (Nahum 3:6). The chapter opens, "Woe to the bloody city! it is all full of lies and robbery" (3:1). The punishment fits the empire: the power that made spectacles of others is itself made a spectacle. Peele's Nineveh is Hollywood, the imperial capital of the image, and the oracle is fulfilled to the letter. After its great feeding, the creature regurgitates over the Haywood house a torrent of blood and indigestible matter (keys, coins, the residue of the devoured), and the abominable filth rains upon the homestead. Julia Kristeva's abject (1980), the expelled remainder that threatens the border of the self, here takes the form of the spectacle's excrement. The filth falls not upon Nineveh's princes but upon the descendants of a man whose image helped found the empire without credit, and the misdirection is the point: the waste of spectacle flows downhill.

The archaic noun repays attention. A gazingstock is an object of the gaze, but the word fuses gaze with stock: livestock, the horses the Haywoods raise and rent; stock-in-trade; capital stock. The gazingstock is the capital of the attention economy, the animal or person whose being-looked-at is the commodity, and the film's architecture follows the word. Its five chapters are named for animals (Ghost, Clover, Gordy, Lucky, Jean Jacket), as if the film were a stud book of performers.

4.2 The Primal Scene of Cinema: Muybridge and Critical Fabulation

In 1878, at his Palo Alto stock farm, the railroad magnate and former governor Leland Stanford commissioned Eadweard Muybridge to settle a question of equine locomotion: whether a horse at speed is ever wholly airborne, a condition the period called "unsupported transit." Muybridge's battery of cameras, tripped in sequence as the horse passed, produced the plates known as *The Horse in Motion*, which proved that it is; projected soon after through his

zoopraxiscope, the sequence became a canonical ancestor of the motion picture. The often-repeated story of a wager behind the commission is probably apocryphal. The rider in the most famous plates is a Black man whom the historical record leaves essentially uncredited.

Nope gives him a name and a lineage. On a commercial set where the white crew barely attends to her, Em Haywood delivers her family's pitch: the rider was Alistair E. Haywood, their great-great-great-grandfather, and Haywood's Hollywood Horses have served the industry since its first frame. Hartman's "Venus in Two Acts" (2008) proposed critical fabulation as a method for writing within the archive's silences without pretending to fill them, a speculative narration that exposes its own invention. Peele's genealogy is critical fabulation in a vernacular register. Its fictionality is flaunted, delivered as patter, and its ironic frame is exact: the descendants of the uncredited can make their history count only by selling it, on the very set where the brother is about to be dismissed.

Walter Benjamin's "Little History of Photography" (1931) coined the phrase "optical unconscious" for what the camera discloses beneath the threshold of the eye, and took as an example what happens in the fraction of a second of a stride. Muybridge's plates are the optical unconscious's founding instance. *Nope* discloses the racial unconscious of the optical unconscious: at the instant the camera first proved what the eye could not see, it recorded, without registering, the Black body upon which the proof depended. Unsupported transit acquires a second meaning. The Black rider suspended above the earth at the moment of capture recalls the legend of the Flying Africans, preserved in Gullah tradition and associated with Igbo Landing in 1803, retold in Virginia Hamilton's *The People Could Fly* (1985) and in Toni Morrison's *Song of Solomon* (1977): captives who rose into the air and flew home. *Nope*'s sky inverts the legend. The sky that promised flight now abducts.

Cinema's narrative birth, D. W. Griffith's *The Birth of a Nation* (1915), was a racist spectacle, and Oscar Micheaux's *Within Our Gates* (1920) is among its earliest answers. The Western, the genre *Nope* finally claims, was built upon a parallel exclusion. Bill Pickett, the Black rodeo star credited with inventing bulldogging, starred in the early 1920s in *The Bull-Dogger*, made for Black audiences by the Norman Film Manufacturing Company, and frequently cited estimates hold that a substantial share of the nineteenth century's working cowboys were Black. The Haywoods are the dispossessed heirs of both cinema and the Western. A further inheritance is concealed in the commission itself. Stanford's fortune derived from the Central Pacific Railroad, whose line across the Sierra Nevada was laid largely by Chinese laborers. The capital that underwrote cinema's primal experiment was accumulated through

racialized labor in the same West whose frontier mythology Jupe Park will package as entertainment.

4.3 The Spectacle Economy and Its Genealogy

Guy Debord's *The Society of the Spectacle* (1967) defined the spectacle not as a collection of images but as a social relation among persons mediated by images. Susan Sontag argued that to photograph is to appropriate (1977) and interrogated the ethics of regarding the pain of others (2003). Herbert Simon (1971) observed that a wealth of information produces a poverty of attention; Tim Wu (2016) and Shoshana Zuboff (2019) traced attention's conversion into the defining commodity of the platform economy. Peele has described the film as an inquiry into the culture's appetite for spectacle. Its originality lies in its genealogy, which locates the attention economy's origin not in the screen but in the exhibition of bodies, human and animal, as a single American institution.

That institution has a history. P. T. Barnum's career began in 1835 with the exhibition of Joice Heth, an enslaved woman advertised as the 161-year-old former nurse of George Washington; after her death he staged her autopsy before a paying audience (Reiss 2001). Sara Baartman was exhibited in London and Paris between 1810 and 1815 as the "Hottentot Venus" and dissected after her death by Georges Cuvier. Ota Benga, a Mbuti man, was displayed in 1906 in the Monkey House of the Bronx Zoo. Buffalo Bill's Wild West, touring from 1883, staged the conquest of the frontier as arena entertainment and in 1885 toured Sitting Bull. Carl Hagenbeck of Hamburg, the era's preeminent dealer in wild animals, also organized *Völkerschauen*, exhibitions of human beings. The animal trade and the human zoo were a single business.

Kafka's "A Report to an Academy" (1917) is that business's most penetrating literary record. Its narrator, Red Peter, an ape shot and captured on the Gold Coast by a Hagenbeck hunting expedition, learns to imitate human beings in order to escape his cage, and he is precise about what he sought: *Nein, Freiheit wollte ich nicht. Nur einen Ausweg*, "No, freedom was not what I wanted. Only a way out." Red Peter anticipates the trilogy entire: an African captive of the animal trade whose aim is not freedom but a way out (*Get Out*), who survives by mimicry (*Us*), and who ends as a variety-stage performer (*Nope*). John Berger's "Why Look at Animals?" (1977) argued that the zoo and the animal spectacle mark the disappearance of animals from human life, the reciprocal gaze that once passed between species across a gulf replaced by a public's look that meets nothing. Jacques Derrida's *The Animal That Therefore I Am* (2006) begins with the philosopher naked before his cat's gaze, ashamed to be seen by an animal. Donna Haraway's *When Species Meet* (2008) proposed

an ethics of response between companion species. *Nope* is a film in which animals look back.

4.4 *Gordy's Home!*

The prologue and the central flashback return to 1998 and the set of a family sitcom starring a chimpanzee. During the taping of a birthday episode, balloons pop; the animal attacks the cast; the child actor Ricky "Jupe" Park hides beneath a table and watches the carnage through the hem of the tablecloth, as through a veil. A shoe stands improbably upright amid the blood. The bloodied chimpanzee approaches the boy and extends a fist for a bump, and a gunshot kills it before their knuckles meet.

Roland Barthes's *Camera Lucida* (1980) distinguished the *studium* of a photograph, its general cultural interest, from the *punctum*, the detail that pricks and wounds. The upright shoe is the punctum of Jupe's memory, the absurd detail that converts a massacre into a sign and seeds his conviction that he has been chosen. The interrupted fist bump is the film's most delicate image: an animal's gesture of recognition across the species line, canceled by the bullet of the order that caged it. Jupe misreads the gesture as the seal of a special bond, the fantasy of exceptional rapport with the wild that has sustained every animal tamer and every colonial friend of the natives, and he transfers it to the creature in the sky, which he has been feeding with horses bought from the Haywoods in preparation for a show.

Jupe is not the Armitages. He is a survivor of spectacle, a child once consumed by it, whose adult strategy is to become its impresario. He keeps a private room of *Gordy's Home!* memorabilia, which he shows to visitors as a curiosity, and recounts with amusement the late-night sketch the massacre inspired. Trauma has become curio; the survivor applies the vicarious contract to his own past. Peele grants him pathos rather than villainy. He is the minoritized subject who escaped the cage by learning to sell tickets to it. His theme park, Jupiter's Claim, is a Gold Rush town in the desert, the frontier that Frederick Jackson Turner declared closed in 1893 rebuilt as a ride, and its name joins the miner's claim, the settler's claim, and the sky god's prerogative.

The balloon binds the film's two catastrophes: popping balloons trigger Gordy's attack, and the creature is destroyed when it swallows a giant inflatable effigy of Jupe in cowboy costume. A third animal completes the series. On the commercial set, a crew member, ignoring OJ's warnings, shows the horse Lucky its reflection in a chrome visual-effects sphere, and the horse kicks; the Haywoods lose the job. Three animals, three triggers: balloons, a mirror, a returned gaze. In each case the animal's violence is provoked by the apparatus of spectacle itself.

4.5 Jean Jacket: Theology and Zoology

The creature first appears as a flying saucer concealed in a cloud that does not move. It swallows horses and people, kills electrical power in its vicinity, and spits out what it cannot digest. In its final form it unfurls into a vast, pale, sail-like membrane organized around a square aperture, a design Peele has linked to the angels of Hideaki Anno's *Neon Genesis Evangelion* (1995–1996) and that many viewers likened to the eyed wheels of Ezekiel's vision. Its theology can be read in five registers.

The first is Ovidian. Semele, mortal lover of Jupiter, is tricked by Juno into demanding that the god appear to her in the full glory in which he appears to his queen; he complies, and her mortal body is incinerated by the epiphany (*Met.* III.253–315). The "bad miracle" Peele's characters invoke is Semele's: a divine spectacle that annihilates its beholder. The showman's name completes the allegory. Jupe, whose nickname shortens Jupiter and whose park asserts Jupiter's claim, believes himself master of the epiphany but plays Semele, consumed by the appearance he summoned before a paying crowd.

The second register is prophetic. Ezekiel's living creatures move upon wheels whose "rings were full of eyes round about them four" (Ezekiel 1:18), an angelic body that is all eye. The third is Rilkean. The First Duino Elegy (1923) holds that beauty is nothing but the beginning of terror (*denn das Schöne ist nichts / als des Schrecklichen Anfang*), and the Second opens with the sentence *Jeder Engel ist schrecklich*: every angel is terrible. Jean Jacket's unfurling is the most beautiful image in Peele's cinema and the most lethal. The fourth is phenomenological. Rudolf Otto's *The Idea of the Holy* (1917) described the numinous as *mysterium tremendum et fascinans*, the mystery that makes one tremble and draws one in; the creature fascinates, and those it fascinates it eats. The fifth is Joban. God's challenge to Job, "Canst thou draw out leviathan with an hook? or his tongue with a cord which thou lettest down?" (Job 41:1), expects the answer no. Jupe's Star Lasso Experience answers yes.

Against this theology the film sets a zoology. OJ Haywood, a horse trainer by inheritance, recognizes the creature as an animal: territorial, predatory, provoked by eye contact as a dangerous horse is provoked. His knowledge comes from labor. The tradition of cosmic horror, from H. P. Lovecraft's "Supernatural Horror in Literature" (1927), which made fear of the unknown the oldest and strongest of fears, to Eugene Thacker's *In the Dust of This Planet* (2011), which theorized horror as thought's encounter with a world indifferent to us, rests upon the epistemic defeat of the human before the incomprehensible. *Nope* opposes to it a Black vernacular epistemology. The unknown is knowable to those whose work has taught them animals; the god is down-

graded to livestock; the epiphany is an appetite. *Nope* is, in this precise sense, a counter-Lovecraftian film.

Hans Blumenberg's *Work on Myth* (1979) held that the first labor of myth is naming, by which the absolutism of reality is reduced to a power one can address. Em names the creature Jean Jacket, after a horse she was promised as a child and never given. The act is Blumenberg's work on myth in miniature, and it inscribes a grievance: a broken paternal promise, a covenant, in Jeremiah's sense, unkept. To name the god after a withheld horse is to domesticate it and to indict the economy that withheld the horse in one gesture.

4.6 The Stain in the Sky

In his eleventh seminar (1964), Jacques Lacan relocated the gaze from the subject's eye to the field of the visible, where it appears as a stain: the anamorphic skull in Holbein's *The Ambassadors* (1533), a blur that resolves, from an oblique standpoint, into death. Lacan recalled a day at sea with fishermen when one pointed to a sardine can glittering on the waves and remarked that Lacan could see the can but the can could not see him; Lacan's lesson was that it was looking at him all the same, and that he was the stain in the picture. The cloud that does not move is Lacan's anamorphic stain made literal: an element of the landscape that, once perceived correctly, discloses death. And in *Nope* the sardine can does see you. The Lacanian gaze becomes a predator. Mark Fisher (2016) defined the eerie as a failure of absence or of presence, something where there should be nothing or nothing where there should be something; the stationary cloud is the eerie in its purest form.

The cloud is also weather. Sharpe's *In the Wake* figures antiblackness as the total climate, the weather in which Black life is lived, and *Nope* literalizes the figure: the predator hides in the weather above the Haywood ranch, and when it feeds it rains blood. The climate is hunting them. The cloud is, finally, a ship. The creature first presents itself as a flying saucer, and when it has fed, the sound design lets us hear, from somewhere within it, the muffled screams of the swallowed. A vessel in the sky whose interior holds the living in agony is the hold transposed to altitude. Mark Dery, coining the term Afrofuturism in 1994, observed that African Americans could be understood, in a very real sense, as the descendants of alien abductees, and Kodwo Eshun (2003) extended the analogy into a program for Afrofuturist criticism; Octavia E. Butler's *Dawn* (1987) had already imagined the abducting craft as a living organism. Jean Jacket completes the figure: the slave ship returned as a predator in the weather, hovering over a Black family's land.

The creature's appetite for electricity extends the conceit. In its presence power fails, digital cameras die, and only unpowered devices continue to work: a hand-cranked film camera, a coin-operated souvenir camera, and a

row of inflatable tube men whose collapse, as their fans lose current beneath the passing creature, becomes a sensor network improvised from roadside advertising, a desert analogue of the yellow barrels by which Spielberg's hunters tracked the shark in *Jaws* (1975). Ellison's invisible man drew stolen current to illuminate his hole; Peele's spectacle devours the very current that makes images.

4.7 Fatal Sight and Its Counter-Techniques

The film's survival rule is the oldest prohibition in the mythology of sight: do not look at it. Orpheus may lead Eurydice out of the underworld on condition that he not look back; he looks, and loses her (*Met.* X). Lot's wife looks back at the burning cities and becomes a pillar of salt (Genesis 19:26). Whoever meets the Gorgon's gaze is turned to stone, and Perseus beheads Medusa by viewing her only in the polished surface of his shield (*Met.* IV–V). Ovid's archive offers two answers to fatal sight: abstention, the Orphic prohibition, and mediation, the Persean mirror.

The prohibition carries a philosophical history specific to Blackness. Jean-Paul Sartre's "Black Orpheus" (1948), his preface to Léopold Sédar Senghor's anthology of Négritude poetry, figured the Black poet as an Orpheus descending into himself to retrieve his Blackness, then subordinated that Blackness as the minor term of a dialectic destined to culminate in a raceless universal. Fanon's response in *Black Skin, White Masks* records the injury of being made a moment in another's progression. Marcel Camus's *Orfeu Negro* (1959), winner of the Palme d'Or, retold the myth in a Rio favela at Carnival, a Black Orpheus produced for an international gaze. *Nope* refuses both the fatal Orphic look and the Sartrean dialectic that would make Blackness a station on another's road.

Its characters enact the alternatives. Antlers Holst, the celebrated cinematographer recruited to capture the impossible shot, bears Actaeon's attribute in his name: the hunter of images who sees what he should not and is devoured. Cranking his hand-powered camera, he walks up a hill into the creature's maw to complete the shot, the classical auteur consumed by his medium's sublime. He is also Ahab, whose quarry's terror Melville located in its color: "It was the whiteness of the whale that above all things appalled me" (*Moby-Dick*, ch. 42). Louis Althusser's scene of interpellation (1970), in which a police officer's hail transforms the individual who turns toward it into a subject, here receives its most literal rendering: to turn and look is to be hailed, and to be hailed is to be eaten.

OJ survives by lowering his eyes, as a wrangler does before a dangerous horse. Édouard Glissant's *Poetics of Relation* (1990) claimed for the colonized the right to opacity, the right not to be rendered transparent to another's

comprehension; OJ's averted gaze is opacity as a technique of survival. Em, meanwhile, pursues what she calls the Oprah shot, the impossible image that would make the family rich and believed, and in doing so asserts what Nicholas Mirzoeff (2011) called the right to look, a countervisuality opposed to the authority to classify and aestheticize that Mirzoeff traced to the plantation overseer. The siblings' improvised apparatus, assembled with Angel Torres, the electronics-store installer who becomes their accomplice, is dark sousveillance in Browne's sense.

The resolution synthesizes Orpheus and Perseus. At Jupiter's Claim, Em drops a coin into the souvenir camera mounted on the park's wishing well, a mechanical device that needs no current, and captures the creature at the instant it swallows the inflatable effigy of Jupe and bursts. The coin closes a circuit opened in the first act, when the Haywood patriarch was killed by a nickel falling from the sky that entered his eye. The nickel was the admission price of the nickelodeon, the first age of mass cinema: the father is killed by the price of a ticket falling through his eye. One coin kills, another redeems, the two faces of the cinematic economy. The photograph is taken at a wishing well, where the paw's last wish is granted. The predator of gazes, finally, is killed by an image. It swallows a simulacrum in Jean Baudrillard's sense (1981), a copy without an original, and dies of it, as Medusa died by her reflection.

4.8 "Nope": The Refusal

The title is the audience's line, the word spoken in the dark when a character walks toward danger. OJ, glimpsing the creature for the first time, says it and retreats, the rare horror protagonist who heeds the audience. Melville's Bartleby (1853) answered every command with "I would prefer not to," a formula Gilles Deleuze (1989) and Giorgio Agamben (1993) read as a potentiality that suspends the order of command without opposing it. "Nope" is Bartleby's formula in Black vernacular: not a counter-command but a withdrawal from the hail. OJ's taciturnity on the commercial set, which the white production reads as unprofessionalism because it wants personality and receives none, is the same faculty that saves his life. His refusal to perform himself is continuous with his refusal to look.

4.9 The Last Image

The film ends with OJ, alive, mounted on Lucky, framed in dust at the gate of Jupiter's Claim. The Muybridge rider is given a name, a face, a horse, and the Western's heroic iconography, and the Black cowboy is restored to the frame from which the genre excised him. Richard Slotkin's *Regeneration Through*

Violence (1973) and *Gunfighter Nation* (1992) traced the American myth of national renewal through frontier violence. Peele's last image proposes regeneration through refusal: the hero lives because he did not look, and the image exists because his sister looked only through an apparatus she controlled.

4.10 Expulsion: The Third Wish

Jacobs's third wish sends the thing away; the knocking stops; the door opens on an empty road. In *Nope* the empty road becomes an empty sky. The third wish's cost in Jacobs is the final relinquishment of the son, the renunciation of the return. In *Nope* the cost is the renunciation of mastery over spectacle, Jupe's dream, and the siblings' acceptance of the witness's position in place of the impresario's. The film's arithmetic is one eye, no interior, and a multitude swallowed: the spectacle as pure appetite. Its hold is ouranic. Its Ovidian figure is Semele, with Actaeon as chorus and Perseus and Orpheus as counsel. Its speech act is negation. And its breach of the vicarious contract is the most complete of the three. The spectators in Jupe's bleachers, the Lucretian shore rebuilt as stadium seating, are the ones devoured, while the substitutes survive by refusing the face-to-face and seizing the apparatus. In *Nope* the shipwreck comes ashore.



5

Chapter Five

The Monkeypaw Corpus and the Comparative Constellation

In nova fert animus mutatas dicere formas / corpora

My mind is moved to tell of forms changed into new bodies.

Ovid, *Metamorphoses* I.1–2

The theory of vicarity extends beyond the films Peele directed into the productions he has curated, and it locates his work within a constellation of horror and mythological fiction that, read together, forms a counter-tradition: works that render substitution visible, and a smaller set that imagine substitution chosen rather than coerced.

5.1 The Auteur as Impresario

Monkeypaw functions as a school as much as a company. It has fostered a recognizable mode of socially allegorical horror, sustained a circle of collaborators (Win Rosenfeld, Ian Cooper, Nia DaCosta, Justin Tipping), and cultivated a house style. Peele's position within it is double: an auteur whose films anatomize spectacle and an impresario whose company produces it. *Nope* acknowledges the contradiction. Jupe Park, the child performer turned showman who sells tickets to the creature, is the trilogy's nearest approach to a self-portrait, and the Oprah shot, the image that would make a Black family rich and believed, is a fair description of what *Get Out* became. The recursion has continued beyond the frame: the film about a theme park built around a monster has itself inspired an attraction at Universal Studios Hollywood (TheWrap, 9 May 2024). Debord called recuperation the spectacle's capacity to absorb its own critique and sell it back. The objection that Monkeypaw has converted the critique of vicarity into a brand is serious, and Chapter Six answers it. Here it suffices that the films anticipate it.

5.2 *Candyman* (2021): The Hive and the Name

Bernard Rose's *Candyman* (1992), adapted from Clive Barker's "The Forbidden" (1985) and transposed from Liverpool to Chicago's Cabrini-Green, followed a white graduate student investigating an urban legend whose avenging spirit was the son of an enslaved man, a portrait painter lynched in the 1890s for loving a white woman. Nia DaCosta's sequel, co-written with Peele and Rosenfeld, returns to a gentrified Cabrini-Green and reconceives the monster as a hive: a lineage of Black men killed by white violence, among them Sherman Fields, a hook-handed man beaten to death by police in 1977 after a false accusation, whose identities the legend absorbs. The legend requires bodies, and each victim becomes the vessel of a collective. Vicarity is here turned to vengeance. The substitutes return, and the hive is the Tethered nation in the form of a ghost story.

The protagonist, the painter Anthony McCoy, builds an installation that invites viewers to perform the legend's mirror ritual, and sells it to an art market that consumes Black death as content; the gallerist and a dismissive critic die. The film's shadow-puppet sequences, designed by the Chicago company

Manual Cinema, narrate the legends in silhouette and recall Kara Walker's cut-paper tableaux of antebellum violence; the silhouette is the form proper to the shadow, from Plato's cave through Andersen to *Us*. The legend's rule, to say his name five times before a mirror, converges with the injunction of the movement for Black lives to say the names of those killed by police, which Kimberlé Crenshaw and the African American Policy Forum extended as #SayHerName. The convergence is Monkeypaw literalism at its most exact: the injunction to remember the dead is granted to the letter, and the dead come back. Avery F. Gordon's *Ghostly Matters* (1997) proposed haunting as a sociological category, the means by which what has been rendered invisible makes its presence felt; *Candyman* stages Gordon's thesis as a franchise.

5.3 *Lovecraft Country* (2020): Cosmic Horror Historicized

Matt Ruff's novel (2016), adapted for HBO by Misha Green with Peele among its executive producers, sends Atticus Freeman, a Korean War veteran and reader of pulp, into a Jim Crow America whose sundown towns and white occult orders are more lethal than its monsters. Its signal episodes literalize the history that Lovecraft's racism had projected as cosmic dread. One returns to the Tulsa massacre of 1921. Another follows Ruby Baptiste as a potion transforms her into a white woman, so that passing becomes body horror and the return to her own skin an agony. A third, set in Korea, centers a *kumiho*, the nine-tailed fox spirit of Korean folklore. Victor LaValle's *The Ballad of Black Tom* (2016) had rewritten Lovecraft's "The Horror at Red Hook" (1927) from the standpoint of a Black hustler in Harlem, and N. K. Jemisin's *The City We Became* (2020) recast Lovecraftian invasion as the gentrifying colonization of New York's living boroughs. The common procedure, which *Nope* shares, replaces cosmic indifference with historical intention. The unspeakable becomes the documented.

5.4 *The Twilight Zone* (2019–2020): The Host

Peele assumed Serling's place as narrator, and the role's title carries a pun the first film had already exploited: a host introduces stories, and a host is a body in which another lives. The revival's premiere, "The Comedian," follows a struggling stand-up, advised to make his act personal, who discovers that whoever he jokes about vanishes from existence. The parable is a Monkeypaw wish, success granted at others' cost, and a theory of comedy's own vicarity, in which the laugh is paid for by its butt; it appeared under the aegis of one of the most successful comedians of his generation. "Replay" follows a Black mother whose camcorder rewinds time, and who rewinds again and again in the effort to bring her son past a racist state trooper to his college campus. The

camcorder is dark sousveillance and Monkeypaw futility at once: the image can rewind the event but not the structure that reproduces it.

5.5 *Wendell & Wild* (2022): Puppets and Prisons

Henry Selick's stop-motion feature, co-written with Peele, gives Key and Peele the voices of two demon brothers who dream of building an amusement park, the fourth such park in the corpus, and follows Kat Elliot, a Black punk teenager orphaned in a car accident for which she blames herself, as she confronts a corporate scheme to revive a dying town as the site of a private prison. The prison-industrial complex anatomized by Angela Y. Davis's *Are Prisons Obsolete?* (2003), Gilmore's *Golden Gulag*, and Alexander's *The New Jim Crow* becomes the film's infernal economy: the town's future is to be redeemed by the confinement of others. Stop-motion is itself the medium of the animated automaton. Heinrich von Kleist's "On the Marionette Theater" (1810) credited the puppet with a grace unavailable to self-conscious humans, and Bergson and Freud located comedy and dread respectively in the puppet's animation; Selick's medium is the uncanny's native ground. His *Coraline* (2009), adapted from Neil Gaiman's novella (2002), had already joined Peele's two obsessions: an Other Mother presiding over a mirrored Other World of doubles, who wishes to sew buttons into a child's eyes.

5.6 *BlacKkKlansman, Hunters, Monkey Man, Him*

BlacKkKlansman (2018) has been treated in Chapter Two as *Get Out*'s chiastic twin. *Hunters* (2020–2023), following a band of Nazi hunters in 1977 New York, exposed the vicarious satisfactions of genre vengeance and, in its first season, the hazards of inventing atrocity for spectacle: the Auschwitz Memorial publicly objected to a fabricated scene depicting a game of "human chess" in the camp. The objection belongs to the history of vicarity, since it concerns the right to make suffering into spectacle on behalf of those who suffered.

Monkey Man (2024), Dev Patel's directorial debut, which Monkeypaw brought to theatrical release through Universal after Netflix had set it aside, follows a fighter who wears a gorilla mask in an underground ring where he is paid to lose: the substitute's pain sold as entertainment. Its mythological armature is Hanuman, the monkey god of the *Ramayana*, devotee of Rama and leaper of oceans, and it shelters its hero within a hijra community. The film gives Monkeypaw's emblem a transcultural genealogy. The monkey-trickster runs from Esu and the Signifying Monkey through Hanuman to Sun Wukong, the Monkey King of the sixteenth-century *Journey to the West*, who wreaks havoc in Heaven.

Him (2025), directed by Justin Tipping from a Black List screenplay by Zack Akers and Skip Bronkie, was billed as "an anti-sports horror movie": a promising young football player is invited to train at the isolated compound of an aging champion quarterback, Isaiah White. Its original title was *GOAT* (TheWrap), and the acronym's double meaning names vicarity's oldest rite. In Leviticus 16 the high priest lays both hands upon the head of the live goat and confesses over it the iniquities of the people, "And the goat shall bear upon him all their iniquities unto a land not inhabited" (16:22). In the sacrificial economy of American sport, the Greatest of All Time and the scapegoat are one animal. That the film's idol bears the surname of Jacobs's family is, whether by design or by the onomastic gravity of the house, a last rhyme with the paw. Its commercial failure (see the Prefatory Note) does not diminish its interest as a document of the Monkeypaw program.

5.7 The Comparative Constellation

Peele's corpus belongs to three overlapping families: a Black horror lineage whose central figures his films complete; a white canon upon which they signify; and a body of mythological fiction, much of it by Black and diasporic writers and filmmakers, in which the logic of substitution is examined, endured, or transformed. The table locates the principal works by their structure of vicarity.

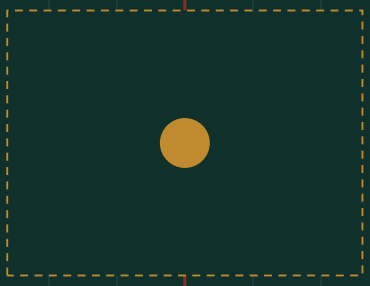
Work	Family	Structure of vicarity	Bearing on Peele
Blacula (William Crain, 1972)	Black horror	An African prince who petitions Dracula against the slave trade is turned and entombed: enslavement rendered as vampirism	Possession as the trade's inheritance (*Get Out*)
Sugar Hill (Paul Maslansky, 1974)	Black horror	A woman summons Baron Samedi's army of the enslaved dead, still in shackles, to avenge her lover	The substitutes rise (*Us*)
Society (Brian Yuzna, 1989)	White canon	A Beverly Hills elite literally absorbs and digests those beneath it	Class as ingestion (*Nope*)
The People Under the Stairs (Wes Craven, 1991)	White canon	Slumlords imprison children beneath their house; a Black boy from their tenements breaks in	The household's underground (*Us*); the white house of horrors (*Get Out*)
Invasion of the Body Snatchers (Don Siegel, 1956; Philip Kaufman, 1978)	White canon	Neighbors replaced by affectless duplicates	Replacement by the double (*Us*)
King Kong (Merian C. Cooper and Ernest B. Schoedsack, 1933)	White canon	A captured beast, exhibited to a theater audience, breaks its chains	Capture of bodies becomes capture of images (*Nope*)

Work	Family	Structure of vicarity	Bearing on Peele
Tales from the Hood (Rusty Cundieff, 1995)	Black horror	A racist politician's plantation house is haunted by dolls holding the souls of the enslaved	The house built over the hold (*Get Out*)
Richard Wright, *The Man Who Lived Underground* (written 1941–42; complete text 2021)	Black literature	A man coerced into a false confession flees into the sewers and watches the city from below	Vision from below (*Us*)
Parasite (Bong Joon-ho, 2019)	Global	A poor family infiltrating a rich house discovers another household hidden in its bunker	*Us*'s twin: the vertical order of households
Atlantics (Mati Diop, 2019)	Global	Drowned laborers possess the women of Dakar to collect wages a developer withheld	Possession as debt collection (*Get Out* inverted)
His House (Remi Weekes, 2020)	Global	Refugees who crossed the sea by claiming another family's child are haunted by her drowning	Survival by substitution; the ghost demands repayment
Squid Game (Hwang Dong-hyuk, 2021)	Global	Indebted contestants die for the wagers of masked spectators	The vicarious contract made explicit
Nanny (Nikyatu Jusu, 2022)	Black horror	A Senegalese nanny raises a white Manhattan child while separated from her son; Mami Wata and Anansi intervene	Coerced surrogacy (Georgina); the global care chain
The Blackening (Tim Story, 2022)	Black horror-comedy	Friends ordered by a killer to choose which of them is the Blackest, to be sacrificed	The genre's sacrificial liturgy parodied
Octavia E. Butler, *Kindred* (1979); *Wild Seed* (1980)	Mythological fiction	A Black woman pulled back in time must keep alive the white ancestor on whom her existence depends; an immortal survives by seizing bodies and breeds human lines	Genealogical vicarity; body-seizure and breeding (*Get Out*)
Toni Morrison, *Beloved* (1987)	Mythological fiction	A murdered daughter returns in the flesh to claim her mother	The return of what was paid (*Us*)
Neil Gaiman, *American Gods* (2001)	Mythological fiction	Gods live on belief and attention; new gods of media contend with old gods carried across oceans, Anansi among them	A god of attention that eats attention (*Nope*)
Hayao Miyazaki, *Spirited Away* (2001)	Mythological fiction	A witch takes a girl's name, and whoever forgets her name cannot return	Renaming as natal alienation (Andre as "Logan")
Guillermo del Toro, *Pan's Labyrinth* (2006)	Mythological fiction	A girl is told she is an underworld princess who forgot herself on the surface; a monster bears its eyes in its palms	The underworld girl above (*Us*); eyes and hands
Rivers Solomon et al., *The Deep* (2019)	Mythological fiction	Descendants of women thrown overboard live beneath the sea; one historian bears the people's memory for all	Chosen vicarity: memory borne, not extracted

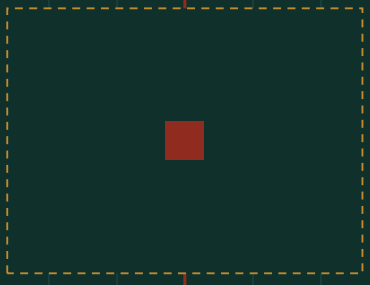
Three conclusions follow. The first concerns the house. Jacobs's first wish is to clear the debt on the house; *Parasite* ends with a son dreaming of buying the mansion above the bunker where his father hides; *Us*'s family owns a lake house and covets a boat; *Get Out* unfolds on an estate; *Nope*'s ranch survives only by selling its horses to the showman next door. In each case the house is the shore, the property in which exemption is secured, and every house in the constellation has a hold. *Parasite* and *Us*, released in the same spring of 2019, share the insight that the substitute who climbs acquires substitutes of his own: Bong's family discovers that someone already lives beneath it. Peele's own plans confirm one line of the genealogy, for a remake of Craven's *The People Under the Stairs* has been in development under his aegis (TheWrap).

The second concerns scale. *Atlantics*, *His House*, *Nanny*, and *Squid Game* globalize the contract through migration, debt, care, and the wager. Arlie Russell Hochschild's account of the global care chain (2000), in which care is extracted from the global South for the households of the North while the migrant worker's own children are cared for by others further down the chain, describes vicarity as a planetary system. Read beside these works, Peele's cinema provincializes America. The "us" of *Us* is a regional dialect of a world grammar.

The third concerns alternatives. Mythological fiction in this constellation sustains a counter-tradition of chosen vicarity. The historian of *The Deep* bears her people's memory so that they may live without it, but she bears it by consent and may set it down; Butler's Dana keeps her enslaver alive at unbearable cost so that her own line may exist, and the novel never lets the cost become invisible. The alternative this tradition imagines is not the abolition of bearing-for-others, which would abolish care itself, but its conversion from coerced to chosen, from concealed to acknowledged, from permanent to shared. Chapter Six names this horizon after the Sumerian goddess who first articulated it.



6



Chapter Six

Shipwreck Without Shore

Toward a General Theory of Vicarity

Il faut parier. Cela n'est pas volontaire, vous êtes embarqué.

You must wager. It is not optional; you are embarked.

Blaise Pascal, *Pensées* (1670)

The preceding chapters converge upon a general theory, which this chapter states as theses, tabulates, situates in a vertical cosmology and in the Ovidian archive, extends to gender, defends against its strongest objections, and completes with an ethics.

6.1 Theses on Vicarity

1 Vicarity is the organized substitution of some bodies for others in labor, sensation, risk, visibility, and death. It is a structure, not an identity; its positions are transferable, and it is maintained by contract rather than by nature.

2 The Atlantic world wrote the vicarious contract upon Black bodies. Race is the historical name of the substitute position, not a metaphor for it, and the position's transferability does not dissolve its history. Sylvia Wynter's account (2003) of the overrepresentation of one genre of the human, Man, as if it were the human itself names the anthropology the contract presupposes.

3 Vicarity operates in three registers at once: economic (fungibility), ontological (social death), and spectatorial (the Lucretian clause). Readings that privilege a single register, whether appropriation, class, or spectacle, mistake a dimension for the whole.

4 The horror film is vicarity's sacrament. It ritually reenacts the substitution and sanctifies the spectator's exemption, and the genre's sacrificial Black figure is its liturgy performed correctly. Achille Mbembe's necropolitics (2003), sovereignty as the power to decide who may live and who must die, is the political theology of which the genre is the popular rite.

5 The liberal individual, the person who in Locke's phrase has "a property in his own person" (*Second Treatise*, §27), is sustained by a system of exceptions. Vicarity is the name of the exceptions, and Peele's films expose the arithmetic the axiom conceals: two minds in one body; one soul in two bodies; one eye without interior and a multitude within it.

6 Empathy is not vicarity's antidote but one of its instruments. Identification with the victim that leaves the victim's position unaltered completes the substitution.

7 Monkeypaw poetics breaches the contract by literalization. A wish or metaphor of the dominant order is granted to the letter, and the substitute who pays for it becomes visible.

8 The trilogy follows the Jacobsian triad of compensation, return, and expulsion, and it traverses Debord's stages of commodity society, from the degra-

dation of being into having to the sliding of having into appearing. The only wish the paw grants without malice is the wish that undoes wishing.

9 Vicarity surrounds its beneficiary on every vertical: within (the endopsychic hold), beneath (the chthonic hold), and above (the ouranic hold). There is no altitude outside the ship.

10 Fatal sight is distributed by position. The substitute's sight is coveted (Actaeon, Tiresias); the beneficiary's self-sight is lethal (Narcissus); the spectator's sight of the spectacle consumes the spectator (Semele, Pentheus).

11 The films are engineered for bifocal address, producing simultaneous and opposed spectatorships across the color line, and they move their spectators from the Lucretian shore through Pascal's embarkation to Bartleby's refusal.

12 The post-vicarious ethic the trilogy proposes is mediated opacity: refusal of the face-to-face with the devouring gaze, joined to the seizure of the apparatus from below. Its social horizon is not the abolition of bearing-for-others, which would abolish care, but the conversion of coerced substitution into chosen and reciprocal sharing: Geshtinanna's offer, not Ereshkigal's law.

6.2 The Schema

The table sets out the trilogy's concurrent axes. Read down a column for a single film; read across a row for the progression the trilogy enacts.

Axis	*Get Out* (2017)	*Us* (2019)	*Nope* (2022)
Wish of the paw	Compensation: a body converted into value	Return: the buried double at the door	Expulsion: the devouring thing sent back
Mode of vicarity	Possessive: the master lives in the substitute	Reciprocal: the substitute lives the master's life below	Spectacular: the substitute's peril sold as image, until the image eats its buyers
Debord's stage	Being degraded into having	Having and its shadow ledger	Having slid into appearing
Hold	Endopsychic: the Sunken Place	Chthonic: the tunnels	Ouranic: the cloud
Sharpe's figure	The hold	The ship	The weather
Arithmetic	Two minds, one body	One soul, two bodies	One eye, no interior, a multitude within
Ovidian figures	Actaeon; Tiresias inverted	Narcissus; Tiresias's prophecy; Cadmus's sown men	Semele; Actaeon as Antlers; Pentheus; Perseus and Orpheus as counsel
Formula of the self	*Actaeon ego sum*: the unspeakable I	*Iste ego sum*: the specular I	The incinerated I
Scriptural or hermetic frame	*Solve et coagula*	Jeremiah 11:11, the broken covenant	Nahum 3:6, the gazingstock

Axis	*Get Out* (2017)	*Us* (2019)	*Nope* (2022)
Speech act of the title	Imperative, addressed to another	Deictic, enrolling the speaker	Negation, the speaker's own refusal
Organ	Eye and ear	Hand	Eye become mouth
Substitute	The purchased Black body	The Tethered	Jockey, chimpanzee, horses, child star, wrangler
Beneficiary	The Armitage clientele	The surface family, "us"	The audience in the bleachers
Apparatus of capture	Hypnosis, neurosurgery, auction	State experiment, mirror	Camera, show, attention economy
Counter-instrument	Camera flash; cotton in the ears; the buck's antlers	Scissors; mimicry reversed	Averted gaze; coin-operated camera; balloon
Founding trauma	A boy watched television while his mother died	A girl wandered into a hall of mirrors	A boy watched a massacre through a tablecloth; a father was killed by a falling coin
Animal emblem	Deer; rabbit as prey	Rabbit as food and experiment	Horse; chimpanzee
Architecture of recreation	Garden party and charity auction	Boardwalk and hall of mirrors	Western theme park and its bleachers
Breach of the contract	The substitute refuses to pay	The substitutes rise and replace	The spectators are eaten; the substitutes survive and take the image

6.3 The Vertical Cosmology

Mircea Eliade's *Shamanism: Archaic Techniques of Ecstasy* (1951) describes a cosmos of three zones, the lower, middle, and upper worlds, joined by an axis mundi along which the shaman travels in ecstasy to retrieve lost souls and heal. *Us* names the axis and commodifies it: the hall of mirrors called "Shaman Vision Quest" is a turnstile to the underworld sold as entertainment. The trilogy as a whole describes a shamanic itinerary whose healer is the substitute: a descent into the self, a descent beneath the nation, an ascent into the sky. Each journey returns, as the shaman's always does, with something retrieved: Chris's self from the Sunken Place, a kidnapped son from the tunnels, an image and a brother from the sky.

Sharpe's maritime figures supply the same verticality: the hold below, the deck, the weather above. The American vertical imaginary, with its upward mobility, its ladder of envy, and the trickle-down economics of the decade of Hands Across America, is literalized in the trilogy as a vertical cosmos of capture. The beneficiary occupies the middle world, the deck, the shore, and the middle world is precisely what the films dissolve. Vicarity lies within the beneficiary, beneath him, and above him. There is no altitude of exemption. The shore was the deck.

6.4 The Jacobsian Triad as Dialectic

The three wishes form a dialectic. Compensation converts a body into value: the person is degraded into a possession. Return confronts the beneficiary with that value as a person who demands the life it paid for: the possessions acquire a ledger, and the ledger acquires a face. Expulsion confronts the system's last form, the image, which has detached itself from the bodies from which it was extracted and now consumes everyone. The sequence reproduces with uncanny fidelity the stages that the seventeenth thesis of Debord's *Society of the Spectacle* assigned to commodity society: first the degradation of being into having, then the generalized sliding of having into appearing. *Get Out* stages the degradation of being into having, a person possessed. *Us* stages the regime of having and its shadow ledger, beach houses and boats and their cost below. *Nope* stages having's slide into appearing, the image as the last commodity.

The triad's resolution is the most philosophically consequential feature of Jacobs's tale. The first two wishes are perverted; the third is granted exactly as intended, and the knocking stops. The paw's malice is exhausted not because it relents but because the third wish asks for nothing. It is a wish to unwish, a renunciation. Peele's trilogy reproduces the asymmetry. *Get Out* and *Us* end in qualified, shadowed victories; *Nope* ends cleanly, the image taken and the brother alive. The difference lies in the object of desire. The Armitages wish for bodies, and the nation wishes for its other half; the Haywoods' desire is transformed in the course of the film, so that the shot they set out to sell becomes, at the wishing well, an act of witness, and the film ends before anyone can sell it. The only wish the paw cannot pervert is the wish that undoes vicarious desire itself.

6.5 An American Book Three

The third book of the *Metamorphoses* is a treatise on fatal sight. Actaeon sees the goddess and is torn apart by his own hounds. Semele demands to see the god and is incinerated. Tiresias, by one account blinded for what he saw and in Ovid for what he said, is compensated with prophecy. Narcissus sees himself and wastes away. Pentheus climbs to spy upon the Bacchic rites, is seen by the women he watches, and is torn apart by his mother, a story Euripides's *Bacchae* (405 BCE) had already made the Western stage's great tragedy of spectatorship. The book opens, moreover, with a founding: Cadmus sowing the serpent's teeth, the earthborn rising to fight their civil war.

Peele's trilogy is an American Book Three, and it revises Ovid's doctrine at one decisive point. Ovid punishes those who see too much. Peele asks who is made to be seen and whose seeing is coveted, and the answer redis-

tributes the punishments by position. Pentheus, the spectator destroyed by the spectacle he would watch from a safe perch, is the ancestor of Jupe's audience in the bleachers. The three Ovidian formulas of selfhood describe three deaths of the ego under the regime of sight: Actaeon's *ego sum*, which cannot be spoken; Narcissus's *iste ego sum*, which kills by being spoken; Semele's I, consumed before it can speak at all. Peele's survivors survive by declining each of these declarations. Chris stops his ears; Adelaide never tells; OJ never looks. Glissant's opacity reappears at the level of the self: under the regime of fatal sight, survival requires a self that does not make itself wholly visible, even to itself.

6.6 The Grammar of Address and Bifocal Address

J. L. Austin's *How to Do Things with Words* (1962) distinguished utterances that describe from utterances that act. Peele's titles act, and each performs a different act. *Get Out* is a directive, a warning issued by a speaker outside the danger to an addressee within it. *Us* is an indexical, and Émile Benveniste's analysis of the pronouns (1946) explains why it is the trilogy's most treacherous word: "we" is not a plurality of identical I's but an I that annexes a non-I under its own predominance, and many languages distinguish an inclusive we (I and you) from an exclusive we (I and they). Red's "We're Americans" is an exclusive we claiming the rights of the inclusive, and the national "us" is an I that annexes those it has excluded. *Nope* is a negation, and Freud's "Negation" (1925) observed that to negate is to take cognizance of the repressed while refusing to accept it: the audience's "nope" admits what it has seen.

The titles also inscribe a vernacular practice. Geneva Smitherman's *Talkin and Testifyin* (1977) analyzed call-and-response as a structuring principle of Black speech, and Jacqueline Najuma Stewart's *Migrating to the Movies* (2005) recovered early Black audiences' active, vocal spectatorship, which she called reconstructive. Each title is the audience's response line. Stuart Hall's encoding/decoding model (1973; 1980) distinguished dominant, negotiated, and oppositional readings of a single message; Manthia Diawara's resisting spectator (1988) and bell hooks's oppositional gaze (1992) theorized Black viewers' refusal of the identifications Hollywood offered them. Peele's innovation is to engineer the divergence into the image itself. Bifocal address constructs images that produce simultaneous and opposed spectatorships across the color line and then synchronize them. Its exemplary instances are the police lights at the end of *Get Out*, Red's declaration of nationality, and the Oprah shot, each received as rescue, claim, or triumph by one audience and as doom, threat, or theft by another, before the film's rhythm reunites them.

Read in sequence, the grammar describes the spectator's journey. *Get Out* places the audience on Lucretius's shore, shouting a warning to a swimmer

in the waves. *Us* places it aboard, in Pascal's sense, inside the pronoun. *Nope* lends the audience's own refusal to the protagonist, Bartleby's formula in Black vernacular. From warning another, through recognizing oneself, to refusing: the grammar of address is the trilogy's moral education of its spectator.

6.7 Gender, Surrogacy, and the Final Girl

Clover's Final Girl, the investigative, androgynous survivor of the slasher who seizes the killer's weapon, is the genre's most influential gendered figure, and Peele redistributes the role across the trilogy. Rose Armitage is the anti-Final Girl: the young white woman who in the classical genre would have survived is revealed as the procurer, keeper of a private archive of photographs of the Black men she has delivered, who at the last calls for help toward the approaching lights in a performance of the weaponized innocence Hamad analyzed. In her the sexual contract that Pateman described operates as the racial contract's lure. Missy Armitage embodies a maternal authority licensed by psychiatry, who sinks Chris through the memory of his mother's death: the good mother as hypnotist. Georgina, read in Chapter Two through Delores Williams's coerced surrogacy and Collins's controlling images, is also the trilogy's emblem of what Moya Bailey named misogynoir, the specific contempt directed at Black women, here rendered as a Black woman's body made the vessel of white matriarchal continuity.

Us gives the Final Girl's role to a Black mother who is also the monster. Adelaide survives because she is what she fights, and Red, archaic mother of a subterranean nation who delivers her people into the light with a pair of scissors, embodies Barbara Creed's monstrous-feminine (1993) in an explicitly political key. Brooks's account of Black women's hauntings finds here its most ambitious cinematic object: the Black woman as both haunted and haunting, narrator of the "once upon a time" and its prisoner. *Nope*, finally, gives the camera to a Black sister. Em is the Final Girl as Perseus, whose weapon is the image, and a hustler whose entrepreneurial patter is the trickster's survival art. The trilogy's arc in gender runs from the white woman as lure, through the Black mother as double, to the Black woman as maker of the image. By the end, the apparatus has passed into the hands of the figure the genre had most consistently consumed.

6.8 Objections and Limits

Five objections deserve answer.

The Afropessimist objection holds that Peele's escapes and survivals are fantasies, since the structure producing the substitute remains intact. The

objection is correct about the structure and mistaken about the films, which mark their escapes as wishes and attach to each a visible cost: the lights that might have been the police, the son behind the mask, the patriarch killed by a falling coin. Stefano Harney and Fred Moten's *The Undercommons* (2013) supplies a vocabulary for what the films depict, which is not liberation but fugitivity, survival beneath a structure that has not fallen. Peele's horror occupies precisely the interval between the pessimist's diagnosis and the fugitive's practice.

The decolonial objection, following Tuck and Yang, holds that *Us* metaphorizes dispossession, and it identifies a real limit of the theory as well as of the film. Patrick Wolfe's account of settler colonialism as a structure governed by a logic of elimination (2006) describes an order that seeks not to use the native as substitute but to remove her and take her place. Vicarity accommodates this only in part. The settler who replaces the native performs a substitution, and Philip J. Deloria's *Playing Indian* (1998) documents the settler's recurrent desire to inhabit Indigeneity, a possessive vicarity analogous to the Coagula, of which the seaside "Shaman Vision Quest" is an instance. But elimination is not reducible to substitution, and a theory of vicarity that forgot the difference would repeat the error it diagnoses.

The objection from recuperation holds that a critique of spectacle sold as spectacle by a commercially successful company has been absorbed by what it criticizes, a charge sharpened by recurrent debates over whether Black horror trades in Black suffering. The films internalize the objection rather than escaping it: *Nope* makes Peele's own position its subject, and his camera, as the next section argues, characteristically refuses to linger on the violence it depicts. Internalization is not refutation, and the objection stands as a condition of the work rather than a verdict upon it.

The intentionalist objection holds that the Jacobsian and Ovidian structures are the critic's constructions. The dissertation concedes the premise and denies its force. Conjunctural mythography claims structure, not intention, and Lévi-Strauss held that myths think themselves in human minds without those minds being aware of it. The test of a structural claim is its explanatory yield, and the structures proposed here connect features of the films that otherwise remain scattered, from the deer to the wishing well.

The universalist objection, finally, holds that vicarity, by generalizing the substitute position, dilutes the singularity of antiblackness on which Wilderson insists. The theory answers that a transferable position still has an origin and a color, and the films keep the hold's color visible even where they generalize its logic. The Tethered nation is multiracial, but its prophet is a Black woman; the spectacle eats everyone in the bleachers, but its first uncredited star was a Black rider.

6.9 Mediated Opacity and the Geshtinanna Principle

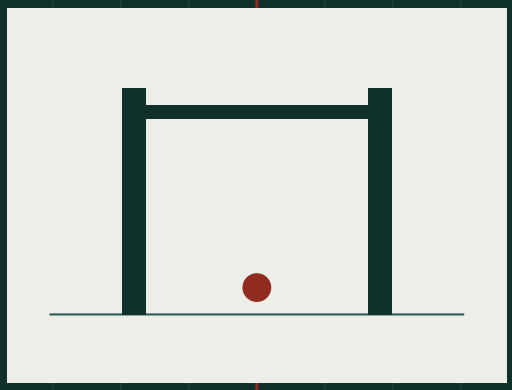
The ethic the trilogy proposes can now be stated in full. It rejects two alternatives. The first is transparency, the face-to-face with the sublime, the right to look pursued as consumption, which the films assign to Jim Hudson, who would buy another's eyes, to Antlers Holst, who walks into the maw, and to Jupe, who stages the god. The second is pure refusal, opacity without an image, which would leave the apparatus to the powerful and the substitute without testimony. Mediated opacity joins the Orphic prohibition to the Persean mirror. It refuses the direct look at the devouring gaze and seizes, from below, an apparatus the subject controls: Chris's flash; Jason's mirroring trick, as he walks backward and leads his double into fire; Em's coin in the wishing-well camera. It is the ethic of a subject who will be neither substitute nor beneficiary, who refuses to be consumed as image and to consume others as image, and who nonetheless insists upon producing images as testimony.

Peele practices the ethic as style. His camera characteristically averts itself at the moment of greatest violence. The Coagula's surgery is never shown; the 1986 substitution is withheld until the end and then given in fragments; the *Gordy's Home!* massacre is seen through the hem of a tablecloth. Hartman warned, in "Venus in Two Acts," against narratives that reproduce the archive's violence in the act of exposing it, and Sharpe called wake work the labor of attending to the dead without making them spectacle. Peele's formal reticence belongs to this tradition. It is the mirror held up to Medusa.

The ethic implies a social horizon, which the trilogy does not stage but makes thinkable. The Sumerian *Descent of Inanna* contains two laws of the underworld. Ereshkigal's law is that no one ascends without leaving a substitute; it is the law of the Tethered and of the vicarious contract. But the myth ends with another arrangement. Geshtinanna, sister of the substitute Dumuzi, offers to share his term, so that each spends half the year below and half above. The difference between extraction and solidarity is not that one involves bearing-for-others and the other does not, for both do. The difference lies in consent against coercion, acknowledgment against concealment, rotation against permanence. I call this the Geshtinanna principle: the conversion of vicarity from a contract imposed upon substitutes into a burden shared among equals. The historian of *The Deep* and Butler's Dana are its literary kin. Read through Geshtinanna, the Tethered uprising demands not the surface's death but the rotation of the underworld's term, and the chain of red figures across the hills in the last shot of *Us* becomes legible as the chain the nation might have formed had the hands been offered rather than seized. Peele's films are horror because they stage this principle's absence. They are philosophy because they make the absence visible.

6.10 Coda: The Deck of the Ship

Lucretius's spectator stood on land and found it sweet to watch another's ordeal at sea. Burke made the sweetness conditional upon distance; Kant made it conditional upon safety; Ruskin, before Turner's slave ship, made the drowning a footnote. Pascal declared that we are all embarked, and Blumenberg traced the slow loss of the shore across the history of European thought. Peele's cinema completes the argument with the evidence that tradition withheld. The shore was built, and it was built upon the hold. Those who stood upon it were never outside the sea. They stood on the deck of the ship, above the people whose suffering kept the deck dry and beneath a weather that would one day come for them as well. *Get Out* opened the hold. *Us* revealed a hold beneath every house. *Nope* brought the weather down upon the spectators. There is no shore. There is the ship, and there is what we do aboard it.



Conclusion

And I saw a new heaven and a new earth: for the first heaven and the first earth were passed away; and there was no more sea.

Revelation 21:1

This dissertation has argued that Jordan Peele's three features form a single composition whose subject is vicarity and whose action is the breach of the vicarious contract. The argument's yield can be assessed across four fields and one method, and it opens five lines of further inquiry.

Horror studies. The theory replaces the paradox of horror with a politics of exemption. The question is no longer why audiences enjoy what frightens them but who pays for the enjoyment. Catharsis, curiosity, the containment of the repressed, masochistic identification, and recreational fear all presuppose the Lucretian clause, and the genre's racial liturgy, from Romero's Ben to Kubrick's Hallorann, is the visible form of that invisible contract. Peele's cinema demonstrates that a genre can be turned against its own sacrament without ceasing to be itself.

Black studies. The concept of transferable positions offers a path through the impasse between Afropessimism's insistence on the structural singularity of antiblackness and the vocabularies of fugitivity and coalition. Vicarity preserves the origin and the color of the substitute position while explaining how the contract enrolls new signatories, which is the question *Us* poses when a Black family reaches the shore. It also adds a spectatorial register to the economic and ontological registers the field has theorized most fully, with Hartman's critique of empathy as its hinge.

Film theory. Apparatus theory, often dismissed as ahistorical, finds its truth in the Sunken Place. The spectator's paralysis before the luminous rectangle is not a universal condition of cinema but a racialized distribution, and the cinema seat and the Sunken Place are twins. Bifocal address names a formal procedure, engineered divergence of spectatorship within a single image, that existing models of reception describe only after the fact.

Mythography. Conjunctural mythography rescues myth from archetypalism by treating it as a logical instrument for contemporary contradictions. Ovid's third book emerges as a political treatise on sight; the Sumerian descent supplies, in Ereshkigal's law and Geshtinanna's offer, the terms of an ethics; and Jacobs's Edwardian chiller proves a structural template of unexpected power.

Method. Monkeypaw poetics, defined by five operations (literalization, double-voicing, vicarious accounting, trickster survival, and generic signifyin(g)), is a describable method, and it can be tested on works beyond Peele's corpus, beginning with the constellation assembled in Chapter Five.

Five lines of inquiry follow. The first concerns Peele's next film. His fourth feature, withdrawn from Universal's calendar after delays that began with the industry strikes of 2023 (*Rolling Stone*), remained unscheduled in mid-2026 with a script reportedly settled. The paw grants three wishes and no more. Whatever Peele makes next will be made after the paw, and whether

it can imagine Geshtinanna's arrangement rather than Ereshkigal's law is the most interesting question his career now poses.

The second concerns the digital replica. The strikes that delayed that film were fought in part over the studios' ambitions for performers' digital likenesses: the industry's own Coagula, a desire to retain a body's image and labor without the person. Synthetic images extend spectacular vicarity into a regime in which the substitute need not exist at all, and a theory of vicarity must follow it there. The third concerns scale: the transnational cinema of the planetary contract, from Seoul to Dakar to the Sudanese diaspora in London, deserves comparative treatment as a genre in its own right. The fourth concerns animals. *Nope* opens a zoopolitics of the image, in which the history of animal spectacle and the history of racial spectacle are written as one. The fifth concerns pedagogy: how Black horror can be taught, as Tananarive Due has taught it, without reenacting the sacrament it exposes.

Jacobs's tale ends at a gate. Having uttered the third wish, Mr. White runs down to his wife "and then to the gate beyond. The street lamp flickering opposite shone on a quiet and deserted road." Peele's trilogy also ends at a gate. Em Haywood, a photograph in her hand, looks toward the entrance of Jupiter's Claim, and out of the dust a rider appears. The difference between the two gates is the whole argument of this dissertation. In Jacobs the third wish restores the parlor: the thing is banished, the cost absorbed in silence, the shore reclaimed. In Peele there is no parlor to return to. The spectators are gone, the sky is empty, and the survivors are those who were never permitted the shore. What they hold is not exemption but evidence. Any future beyond the vicarious contract will have to be built from evidence, not from exemption.

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Filmography of the Corpus

Listed chronologically, as the dissertation reads the corpus as a sequence.

Year	Title	Peele's role	Notes
2003–2008	*MADtv*	Cast member	Sketch comedy
2012–2015	*Key & Peele*	Co-creator, writer, performer	With Keegan-Michael Key
2016	*Keanu*	Co-writer, producer, performer	Directed by Peter Atencio; co-written with Alex Rubens
2017	*Get Out*	Writer, director, producer	Academy Award for Best Original Screenplay
2018	*BlacKkKlansman*	Producer	Directed by Spike Lee
2019	*Us*	Writer, director, producer	Premiered at South by Southwest
2019	*Weird City*	Co-creator, executive producer	With Charlie Sanders
2019–2020	*The Twilight Zone*	Host, narrator, executive producer	Revival of Rod Serling's series
2020	*Lovecraft Country*	Executive producer	Developed by Misha Green from Matt Ruff's novel
2020–2023	*Hunters*	Executive producer	Created by David Weil
2021	*Candyman*	Co-writer, producer	Directed by Nia DaCosta; co-written with Win Rosenfeld and DaCosta
2022	*Nope*	Writer, director, producer	Photographed in large-format IMAX by Hoyte van Hoytema
2022	*Wendell & Wild*	Co-writer, producer, voice performer	Directed by Henry Selick
2024	*Monkey Man*	Producer	Directed by Dev Patel
2025	*Him*	Producer	Directed by Justin Tipping

Keywords

Jordan Peele; Monkeypaw Productions; *Get Out*; *Us*; *Nope*; vicarity; vicarious contract; Racial Contract; Lucretian spectator; shipwreck with spectator; Monkeypaw poetics; Signifyin(g); trickster; "The Monkey's Paw"; conjure tale; *zonbi*; social thriller; Black horror; horror studies; paradox of horror; Final Girl; the uncanny; the double; abjection; return of the repressed; the sublime; spectatorship; apparatus theory; the gaze; oppositional gaze; bifocal address; grammar of address; speech act theory; mediated opacity; right to opacity; right to look; dark sousveillance; society of the spectacle; attention economy; racial capitalism; fungibility; social death; Afropessimism; fugitivity; the hold; the wake; Middle Passage; organized abandonment; settler colonialism; surrogacy; misogynoir; womanist theology; substitutionary atonement; scapegoat; double consciousness; minstrelsy; Ovid's *Metamorphoses*; Actaeon; Narcissus; Semele; Tiresias; Cadmus; Pentheus; *Descent of Inanna*; Geshtinanna principle; Plato's cave; katabasis; structural analysis of myth; conjunctural mythography; critical fabulation; Afrofuturism; Muybridge; Western genre; animal studies; human zoo